

Information Management Review Final Report

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The Office for the Coordination
Of Humanitarian Affairs



Prepared by:

Mary Lee Kennedy, Laurence Prusak, and Bruce Strong

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1 Executive Summary

Information management (IM) is complex for any global organization with diverse stakeholders. OCHA is no exception. Unfortunately, this means that there are no silver bullets.

Benefits: While effective IM is difficult to achieve, its benefits, and what they would mean to OCHA, are easy to enumerate.

- *For senior management*, effective IM means that OCHA's IM products form a clearly understood, coherent, and *manageable* catalog. It means that senior management can easily judge OCHA's IM performance in terms of quality, impact, and innovation (i.e., the degree to which the IM products provide distinctive value.) Senior management can also easily see how much IM costs across the organization and be able to hold individuals accountable for results. Strategically, effective IM means that OCHA can become a provider of choice for insight into humanitarian issues.
- *For users of humanitarian information*, effective IM means that information is less expensive to find and use, information reaches those who need it faster, and that information provides more valuable insight for decision making. Also, OCHA becomes a more predictable provider of information products and services.
- *For OCHA's IM product and service owners*, effective IM means faster and less expensive product development and maintenance, greater ease in promoting products through well-established communications channels, more effective evaluation of the value and use of the IM products, and higher quality.

Overall Assessment: In order to achieve OCHA's **vision of becoming the knowledge broker and an intellectual leader for the humanitarian community**, the way the organization manages information will need to be significantly overhauled. IM as it is currently practiced at OCHA is "not fit to vision."

While individual products and services receive high marks for effectiveness, they range in quality from very good to poor. OCHA's 'can do' attitude and entrepreneurial spirit have led it to undertake many needed initiatives, but without a clear focus on how the resulting products address stakeholder needs in the aggregate. Leveraging content or processes across products and services¹ is difficult because most were built in individual silos, and hence there is little interoperability among them. Our assessment of the IT infrastructure indicates that there is a need for a shared platform to reduce duplication, development time, and costs and to improve quality.

OCHA today is at a crossroads. It has successfully positioned itself with the donor, partner, and funding community as a leader in coordination, advocacy, and policy development. Successful products such as IRIN and ReliefWeb have brought high expectations. For all of OCHA's information products and services to consistently meet those expectations will require a more coherent and disciplined approach to IM. While OCHA's role in humanitarian relief is a mandated one, the market for ideas and funding in the humanitarian arena is competitive. Failure to improve its IM performance could mean that OCHA will lose its hard-earned leadership position.

Recommendations: Four of the five recommendations in this report are foundational and serve to enhance OCHA's ability to deliver the benefits of effective IM; without them substantial progress towards becoming an intellectual leader is impossible. While they will benefit OCHA and its constituents, they

¹ By IM products and services, we mean reports, Web sites, and services such as the HICs, the CAP, and the FTS.

will do so indirectly. The first recommendation is a clear manifestation of OCHA's IM value and provides a tangible guiding principle for much of OCHA's IM work. We put it first because it is the most visible and profound difference OCHA can make to its many constituents.

1. **Recommendation: Create an organization-wide, cross-cluster knowledgebase for key humanitarian information and analysis.** OCHA, through its own efforts and in collaboration with its partners and donors, has access to a vast amount of information relevant to the humanitarian community. If this information were to be collected, vetted, shared, analyzed, and disseminated in a systematic way, OCHA could become *the* authoritative source and collective record for the humanitarian community.

Turning this concept into reality will be no minor feat. Key sectoral indicators would need to be defined, normalized, and baselined. The common needs assessment effort, being led by PDSB and sponsored by ECHO, would be foundational to making the knowledgebase work. *Every* OCHA IM product or service – whether situation reports, 3W, HICs, CAPs, or FTS – would by default be designed to feed into the knowledgebase.

The rewards would be substantial. This type of online resource could provide the organizing principle for all of OCHA's outward-facing IM activities, one that OCHA currently lacks. It could also be a game-changing move for OCHA. With this visible, well-managed, and comprehensive online resource, OCHA could legitimately demonstrate intellectual leadership within the humanitarian community because it would have the relationships, the information, and the analytic and communication skills to underpin that position. This repository – and the system of collecting, vetting, sharing, analyzing, and disseminating information that supported it – could dramatically improve OCHA's reputation and brand promise to the world. It could also serve as a base to enable OCHA to fully enter into the practice of knowledge management.

Similar efforts by organizations such as the World Bank with its “Doing Business Project” and the Food Security Analysis Unit (FSAU) for Somalia have made them the recognized leaders in their respective areas and provide inestimable benefit to their constituents.

The other four recommendations detail the changes to governance, innovation, standards practices, capabilities, and technology that will be required to improve OCHA's IM performance and that could provide a basis for an OCHA knowledgebase to exist.

2. **Recommendation: Revise the way IM is governed.** Effective oversight of information management is the single most important predictor for creating value. IM oversight is an executive management responsibility. No organization with which the IM Review Team is familiar – *not one* – has created and sustained a successful IM program without substantial executive management oversight.

OCHA's oversight is better than that of some organizations we have surveyed, but nowhere close to the leaders or at an optimal level. To improve oversight of IM, we recommend that the Senior Management Team (SMT) approve this governance framework:

Enforce 7 IM guidelines – to be applied to every IM product – to support OCHA's IM vision:

1. Every IM product is considered to be part of a managed portfolio.
2. Each information category (domain) has a designated owner.
3. Unconnected information islands should be avoided.
4. When practical, the unit of analysis should be information, not documents.
5. Information – normalized and with clear provenance – is collected only once and re-used as necessary.
6. IM is seamlessly embedded into OCHA's practices.

7. Information can be easily manipulated and viewed in ways that make sense to OCHA's stakeholders.

Create an IM Product portfolio approach

Our assessment indicates that no *one* role is responsible for meeting the information needs of the users of OCHA's IM products and services for five key functionally based audiences: advocacy, coordination, funding, internal communications, and policy. Furthermore, there is no role at OCHA that systematically assesses the impact of the products and services on key audience needs or expectations, let alone whether they do or do not further the strategic objectives of the organization. Interviews uncovered critical needs that could be addressed by a portfolio approach:

- **Provide stakeholder and service catalogs.** Like any organization that provides services, OCHA should present stakeholders with an easily understood and accessible product catalog. This includes understanding what stakeholder information needs are and meeting them.
- **Improved interoperability.** A portfolio approach would help to ensure that OCHA's IM products were consistent and efficient to use and maintain. Currently, there are significant redundancies and information sharing and integrity issues.
- **Sharing of best practices.** A portfolio approach would allow for more sharing of best practices among the builders and users of the portfolio's products.

OCHA should assign a single point-of-accountability for each one of its five product areas: advocacy, coordination, funding, policy, and internal communications. In addition to these five portfolio owners, there should also be an overall portfolio coordinator for *all* of OCHA's IM products and services to ensure that the entire portfolio is on point strategically, to maintain overall interoperability, and to ensure that the portfolio is balanced across stakeholders in terms of resource investment against priorities.

Create an IM services approach

OCHA's IM could be better supported by a well-managed infrastructure of shared services, some technical, some not. Examples of these services include search facilities, usability testing services, controlled vocabularies and metadata management services, evaluation tools and metrics to measure user satisfaction and information category (domain) management. Most of these services are currently provided as one-offs for specific products.

Governance Summary

These oversight recommendations will not require changing reporting lines or changes to the structure of the organization. However, they will require a change in focus and in the degree of accountability. A governance framework will allow the organization to engage in a conversation that spans all of OCHA's IM products and services. This conversation will lead to increased coherence across the entirety of OCHA's information work and will reveal better and more coherent ways to support key audiences.

3. **Recommendation: Systematize the way innovation is spread and standards are set.** Innovation is a strategic imperative for OCHA. Externally, the world is in constant flux. The number and types of humanitarian crises OCHA must address are constantly changing. Internally, OCHA's role is constantly evolving as well. For OCHA, doing things the same way today as yesterday is not viable.

OCHA is blessed with an exceptionally entrepreneurial culture. OCHA staff working directly with partners and donors bring a great deal of imagination to solving real problems. Nonetheless, from an IM perspective, OCHA generally does a poor job of harnessing the imagination of its staff. At best, innovations, whether they are from the front office or the field, are not spread across the organization

as best practices. At worst, innovators are branded as mavericks who “don’t follow the rules” and need to be suppressed.

As noted by numerous scholars of innovation, the most difficult thing for an organization to do is to become aware of the important innovation generated by their staff and then to operationalize it throughout the organization. The IM Review Team has encountered at least two areas within OCHA that could be effective promoters of local IM innovation to the organization as a whole:

1. Regional offices have a unique perspective on what works and does not work at the local level. They are able to see patterns invisible to both country offices below and senior management above. It might be useful to have innovation discovery as part of their terms of reference.
2. AIMB has convocation power for all of the Information Management Officers across OCHA. It should listen for innovations and act to promote them by helping to make them more robust, easier to distribute, and, when appropriate, standardized.

This report suggests a way to systematically gauge the degree to which the organization is innovating and the degree to which this innovation (or best practice) is being spread across the organization. (For more on this, see section 4.4.1 “Innovation.”)

Standardization and innovation are closely related. Without standards, how do you know you are actually innovating? What is the baseline for improvement? And how does the organization benefit from innovation unless it standardizes upon it? Without standards – and this is the case at OCHA – employees improvise solutions, but they cannot really create sustainable innovation.

The ability to innovate in impactful ways is enabled by standards – and seriously hindered by the lack thereof. In their adoption, standards facilitate the realization of other benefits. They:

- facilitate effective decentralization
- create predictability and reliability
- promote efficiency

It is incumbent upon OCHA to become adept at developing, coordinating, and promulgating standards. To do so, OCHA should remember that: ***An effective standards body is the steward, and not the owner, of the standards it produces.*** The owners of the standards are those entities to which the standards apply.

The implications of this statement are essential. In adopting this fundamental principle, we believe, OCHA will be more effective at setting standards. For instance, field staff fear standards coming out of HQ that “are the lowest common denominator” that “stifle creativity and innovation.” As there is no sense of ownership of standards in the field, there is no widespread adherence to them.

In order for OCHA to be an effective standards steward, HQ will need to learn how to facilitate standards creation, maintenance, and exceptions processes. Standards-setting is notoriously difficult and tedious. Nonetheless, even fiercely competing organizations – such as Microsoft, Sun Microsystems, and IBM – have agreed to standards created by neutral standards bodies, because the standards benefit everyone.

4. **Recommendation: Enhance OCHA’s capacity to use technology to support its IM needs.** While the focus of this review is information management and how it should be used to help provide insight for decision making, information technology is a key enabler for IM and must be addressed.

In its interactions with IT staff, the IM Review Team has been impressed by their competence and dedication. Nonetheless, IT at OCHA is not as effective as it could be, and a significant portion of OCHA's infrastructure is out-of-date. On the basis of our assessment, we believe that there are opportunities to do the following:

- Improve OCHA's IT architecture to make IM applications easier to create and less costly to maintain
- Improve OCHA's application development process
- Reduce IT resource bottlenecks through outsourcing
- Make the field the progenitor of field applications and FIS their steward
- Have ITS help measure the value of IT investments

These changes will require significant investment over several years.

5. **Recommendation: Improve OCHA's IM capabilities.** There are critical capabilities that OCHA leadership and staff must develop to take the IM Review Team's recommendations forward. In most cases, OCHA already has these skills, but they are not deployed everywhere that they need to be.

In order to improve its ability to collect, vet, share, analyze, and disseminate information, OCHA needs to systematically teach journalistic skills: networking to find the best sources of information; developing a nose for a story; protecting sources when necessary; and developing the ability to synthesize and analyze information across disciplines. OCHA also needs to develop the statistical skills necessary to vet and analyze information. While country offices may not have enough demand for these skills to justify a position, regional offices might.

Standards administration is as much an art as it is a science. Standards stewards within OCHA should receive training on how to facilitate standards creation, promulgation, and enforcement.

Finally, OCHA needs to develop IM governance skills. These include: IM Services Coordination, IM Product Portfolio Coordination, and IM Product Management. Those placed in these roles should be given basic training on how to fulfill them successfully and be brought together on a regular basis to learn from each other.

Decisions Points and Implementation Roadmap. As this report asserts throughout, governance is a, if not the, critical success factor for effective IM management.

Section 5, "Decisions Points and Implementation Roadmap," asks the SMT to make eight clear decisions in order to initiate IM governance that will create organization-wide accountability for achieving this report's recommendations. It then provides a high-level roadmap for implementation. Finally, it recommends the establishment of an IM Governance Team, reporting directly to the USG, to oversee OCHA's enterprise IM program.

2 IM Review's Objective, Scope, and Investigative Process

Information is central to OCHA's role in humanitarian aid coordination, policy, funding, and advocacy. Information Management (IM) helps OCHA effectively deliver targeted information that provides insight for decision-making.² (See Annex 1 for Glossary on IM terminology).

2.1 Objective

The objective of this review was to determine whether OCHA is providing the right information products and services in the most efficient and effective way possible. Specifically, the Terms of Reference specifies that the IM Review address the following questions:

- What type of IM support would be required to ensure optimum implementation of the humanitarian reform as a strategic priority of OCHA?
- How can IM best support internal work processes (administration, work planning, information sharing, etc.) to improve operational efficiency?
- What type of IM support is required to field operations in order for OCHA to realize a more coherent and unified global presence?
- What type of IM framework should OCHA develop so it can provide the foundation for evidence-based decision making, knowledge management and organizational learning?
- What is the current state of IM/ITS support in OCHA? To what extent does the current ITS infrastructure (Websites, data warehouses, document/content management systems, information sharing platforms, and applications development capabilities) meet the needs of internal clients as well as external partners? What are the strengths and weaknesses of the current set-up and how can existing capacity be utilized to develop a new, up-to-date system?
- What is the ITS capacity required to address improvements in above areas?
- What would be the minimum and optimum level of resources and capacities required to upgrade existing systems?

2.2 Scope

Because information is fundamental to how OCHA does its work, the scope of the review was necessarily broad. We took into account OCHA's diverse IM stakeholders, including the field, donors, partners, and HQ. We examined OCHA's organizing principles (including its mission, vision, and how managers are held accountable.) We analyzed OCHA's key practices (including how OCHA innovates and sets standards). And we reviewed OCHA's use of technology. We looked at all these factors because collectively they determine the direction of OCHA's IM products and services and their level of success.

The scope of the review was broad in another way. OCHA does not deliver food, provide medicine, or build shelter. It collects, vets, analyzes, shares, and presents information so that the humanitarian community can make informed decisions about how to respond optimally to humanitarian crises. There is the sense both within and outside of the organization that OCHA, has not yet optimized its management and use of this key resource. Because of the centrality of information to OCHA's mission, the IM Review Team has not limited itself to recommending incremental changes to the way OCHA handles information. As will become clear, we are proposing significant change. That said, most of the changes we propose for OCHA are already being modeled by pockets of innovators both at HQ and in the field. Thus, while the changes we are proposing would alter the way OCHA manages information, most of the

² The IM Review makes a clear distinction between IM and Information Technology (IT). While IM provides OCHA and its constituents the information they need to make effective decisions, IT is just one of several practices (albeit an important one) that underpin IM's ability to do so.

recommendations are already in effect somewhere in the organization. It has been our conscious intent to anchor our recommendations in the work of these “positive deviants.” In other words, we recommend that OCHA plays to its strengths.

2.3 Investigative Process

The IM Review was designed to take place over three phases. Phase I – the Assessment Phase – consisted of a high-level assessment of IM at OCHA. The IM Review consultants held hour-long interviews with over 100 OCHA staff in New York, Geneva, and Sweden at the FIM/HIC training. We also held phone interviews with 19 donors and partners. To inform the process we undertook an extensive literature review of IM-related reports. We also read all of OCHA’s unit-level work plans, a draft copy of the Field Office Review, and recent OCHA annual reports. Three facilitated group sessions were held, two of which examined OCHA’s current knowledge management capability, while the third sought to identify the top five critical success factors in a humanitarian response. We also evaluated OCHA’s IM oversight capabilities and practices and benchmarked them against those of several other organizations.³ Finally, we reviewed the Intranet, OCHA Online, the HIC Websites, the field office Websites, and ReliefWeb for common visual design, usability, and information architecture, including an assessment of which IM services should exist across the different sites.

With anything as complex as OCHA’s IM practice, the devil is in the details. Phase II ‘ground truthed’ the recommendations made in Phase I, and sharpened the understanding of issues, by looking closely at five OCHA products and services:

- The CAP
- ReliefWeb
- Situation Reports
- HICs
- Policy & Guidance

These products and services were chosen because they are vital to OCHA’s mission. They also collectively touch on each of the three key recommendations from **Phase I** of the review:

- Improve oversight of IM
- Develop the capability to create and enforce IM standards and practices
- Upgrade the information technology infrastructure that underpins OCHA’s IM efforts

In addition to working with the five product owners, the IM Review Team also interviewed more than 40 people including country and regional staff, partners, and donors in Ethiopia, Uganda and Kenya (including Nairobi based staff working on Somalia).

Across Phases I and II, the IM Review Team interviewed donors from USAID, DFID, the Government of Australia, ECHO, and the Government of Canada. The partners interviewed include CARE, FAO, FSAU, the Norwegian Refugee Council, UNDP, IFRC, WHO, UNJLC, WFP, DPKO, ICRC, MSF, UNICEF, UNFPA, UNOSAT, and UNHCR.

The primary outputs of **Phase II**, as embodied in this report, are an updated assessment with detailed recommendations and a roadmap to implement them. **Phase III**, if OCHA decides to move forward on the recommendations, will be the implementation phase.

³ This work was not included in the report for space considerations but is available upon request and is also available on the IM Review page of the OCHA Intranet.

3 Overall Assessment

While assessing OCHA's IM organizing principles, practices, and technology, it became clear that OCHA's IM resembles that of other young organizations that have gone through significant growth. For young organizations, there is little time to develop an organization-wide IM strategy. And even if there were, with so many rapidly evolving needs to address, a meaningful IM strategy would be difficult if not impossible to create in the face of mission and organizational flux.⁴

When both the internal and external working environments are quickly changing, organizations tend to develop "point solutions" to address a specific problem rather than a coherent "portfolio approach" built upon an infrastructure of common principles, practices, and technology. Over time, the results of this type of approach tend to be uneven in quality, with a higher than optimal price tag. Organizations at this stage of development tend not to have focused their cross-organizational IM efforts. Rather, individual managers take it upon themselves to solve problems that they see without a great deal of consideration for the bigger picture, in part, because senior management has not provided clear priorities or measures for success.

Our analysis indicates that this has been the case at OCHA. While individual products and services receive high marks for quality and effectiveness, overall OCHA's products and services range in quality (according to those whom we interviewed) from very good to poor. OCHA's 'can do' attitude and entrepreneurial spirit have led it to undertake many needed initiatives, but without a clear focus on how the resulting products address stakeholder needs in the aggregate. Leveraging content or processes across products and services is difficult because most were built in individual silos, and hence there is little interoperability among them.⁵ Our assessment of the IT infrastructure indicates that there is a need for a shared platform to reduce duplication, development time, and costs and to improve quality.

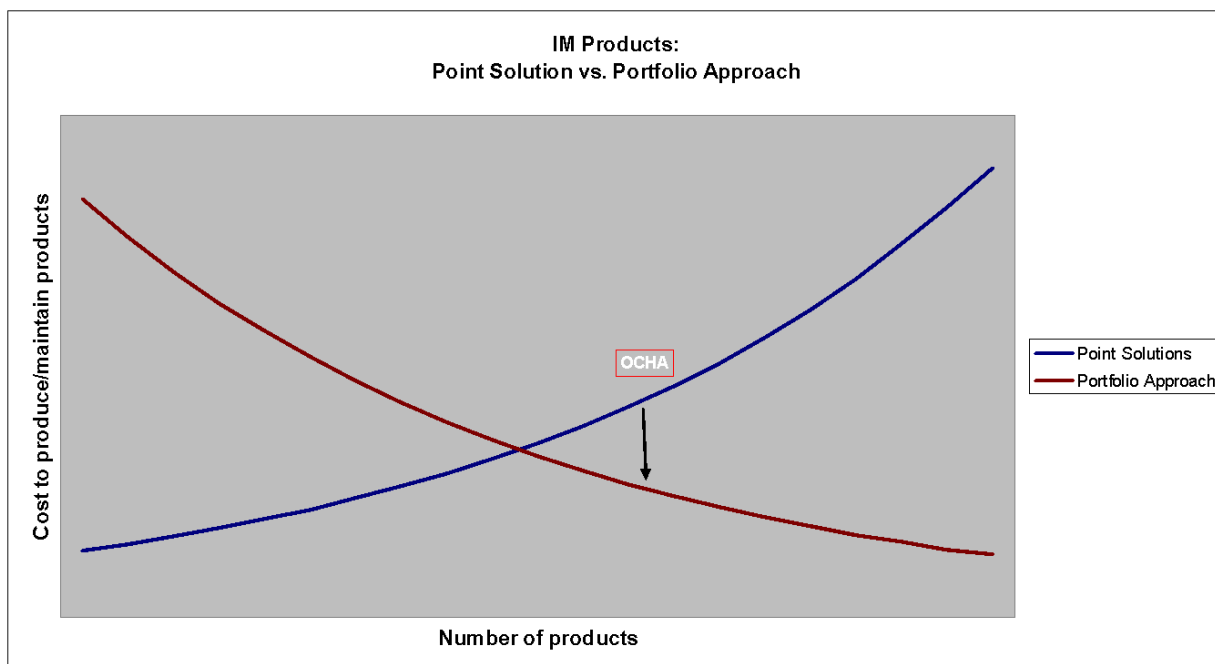
Figure 1 shows the relationship between the number of IM products and the cost of producing and maintaining them under two approaches: point solution and portfolio. Initially, the point solution approach is less expensive because there is no need to spend the additional overhead in planning and architecting the solutions. With very few products, it is generally less expensive not to "over think" solutions.

For a young organization, the point solution approach to IM often makes sense. However, this approach becomes difficult to sustain over the long term. As siloed products and services accumulate, they become more expensive to maintain, and the opportunity costs of their not working together grow. These costs include user and product owner frustration, which is accentuated in OCHA's case by its cross-organizational responsibility to service the humanitarian community.

We believe that OCHA is on the point solution curve somewhere after the two lines have crossed. Today, the more OCHA increases the number of its IM products using a point solution approach, the more costly it will be on a per product basis than if OCHA were using a portfolio approach. Part, though by no means all, of the IM Review's goal is to help OCHA move from the blue "point solution" curve to the red "portfolio approach" one.

⁴ Often even mature organizations don't develop a coherent IM strategy. IM is not taught in most professional schools and is generally relegated to a position of low importance even in MBA programs.

⁵ For instance, there are at least six different country databases, with a great deal of overlap, maintained at OCHA. Across HICs, there are several different content management methods, making the information stored in them difficult to systematically use in other IM products.



OCHA today is at a crossroads. It has successfully positioned itself with the donor, partner, and funding community as a leader in coordination, advocacy, and policy development. Successful products such as IRIN and ReliefWeb have brought high expectations. Consistently meeting those expectations for all of OCHA's information products and services will require a more coherent and disciplined approach to IM. While OCHA's role in humanitarian relief is a mandated one, the market for ideas and funding in the humanitarian arena is competitive. Failure to improve its IM performance could mean that OCHA will lose its hard-earned leadership position.

There are other reasons why OCHA needs to move with urgency to improve its IM performance:

- The humanitarian response environment is becoming increasingly complex. Partners and donors have high expectations of OCHA's IM capabilities. Internally, interviewees consistently cited the need for OCHA to deliver information that is current, relevant, and credible. OCHA will need to collect, vet, share, analyze, and disseminate information more efficiently and effectively to meet these challenges.
- Organizations similar to OCHA, both in the United Nations and external to it, may have superior IM capacities, the most obvious example being UNDP's knowledge network⁶, UNHCR's Standards and Indicators⁷, and Somalia's Food Security Analysis Unit (FSAU).⁸ OCHA must at least keep pace with partner organizations.

⁶ According to their literature, UNDP's Knowledge Network improves "UNDP's capacity to become a knowledge organization by drawing on local, regional and global expertise and promoting the exchange of more nuanced information. Enhances the delivery, relevance and effectiveness of our work and advisory services." For more information, view: [Connecting people i UNDP - Knowledge Networks](#).

⁷ UNHCR Standards and Indicators can be found at: <http://www.unhcr.org/statistics/40f3ac4d4.html>

⁸ www.fsausomali.org

- OCHA is seen as *the* organization responsible for interoperability of information within the humanitarian community. OCHA must have the ability to vet and share information from a variety of sources in meaningful ways, while respecting the integrity of the source and being able to integrate it and compare it with other sources.⁹ However, the majority of partners, donors, and field individuals we interviewed expressed significant frustration with the slowness and impracticality with which OCHA is enabling this process.
- Increasingly, OCHA is seen as the organization that has the mandate to present a global, holistic view of humanitarian information and insight. Yet, OCHA is not perceived as consistently having this capacity.
- With the CERF, the Humanitarian Response Fund, and pooled funding, OCHA has become a significant donor for the first time in its existence. This position offers OCHA considerable new leverage to obtain information from partners. OCHA should take advantage of this opportunity to improve the scope and quality of its situational analyses. On the other hand, working with hundreds of millions of dollars also carries inherent and grave risk. If these monies are mishandled, OCHA's reputation could be irreparably harmed. While financial tracking was not an emphasis of this review, the IM Review Team nonetheless would urge OCHA to use IM techniques to monitor the efficacy and propriety of its funding activities.
- Our interviews revealed significant internal cynicism at all levels about OCHA's desire and will to do anything about improving IM. Individual efforts at improving IM within pockets of activity should be seen not only as entrepreneurial but also as a vote of non-confidence in senior management's ability to effectively lead and drive excellence in IM.

Overall, our interviews revealed a great deal of appetite on the part of partners and donors for OCHA to take a leadership role in humanitarian reform and in the way IM is used to support it. Several players indicated that OCHA has not yet provided enough guidance in the reform process and that OCHA's leadership position was by no means yet established. In all areas of IM – the collection, vetting, analyzing, sharing, and distribution of information – OCHA needs to become more coherent, efficient, and effective in order to earn its leadership mantle. It is the goal of this report to provide actionable recommendations that will allow OCHA to do this.

⁹ The Who's Doing What Where (3W) application is currently under development by FIS to achieve this type of cross-cluster interoperability in line with IASC agreed recommendations.

4 Benefits and Recommendations

Information management (IM) is complex for any global organization with diverse stakeholders. OCHA is no exception. Unfortunately, this means that there are no silver bullets. Given the expected benefits, and the overall assessment the IM Review team provides five recommendations to support OCHA becoming the knowledge broker and intellectual leader for the humanitarian community.

While effective IM is difficult to achieve, its benefits, and what they would mean to OCHA, are easy to enumerate.

Benefits: While effective IM is difficult to achieve, its benefits, and what they would mean to OCHA, are easy to enumerate.

- *For senior management*, effective IM means that OCHA's IM products form a clearly understood, coherent, and *manageable* catalog. It means that senior management can easily judge OCHA's IM performance in terms of quality, impact, and innovation (i.e., the degree to which the IM products provide distinctive value.) Senior management can also easily see how much IM costs across the organization and be able to hold individuals accountable for results. Strategically, effective IM means that OCHA can become a provider of choice for insight into humanitarian issues.
- *For users of humanitarian information*, effective IM means that information is less expensive to find and use, information reaches those who need it faster and that it provides more valuable insight for decision making. Also, OCHA becomes a more predictable provider of information products and services.
- *For OCHA's IM product and service owners*, effective IM means faster and less expensive product development and maintenance, greater ease in promoting products through well-established communications channels, more effective evaluation of the value and use of the IM products, and higher quality.

We believe that every recommendation we make contributes to one or more of these benefits.

4.1 Enable OCHA's IM Vision

In order to achieve OCHA's vision of becoming a knowledge broker and an intellectual leader for the humanitarian community, the way the organization manages information will need to be significantly overhauled. IM as it is currently practiced at OCHA is "not fit to vision."

This section will recommend a new logical framework for OCHA that we believe will enable OCHA to achieve its vision. The components of this new framework are:

1. Creating an organization-wide cross-cluster knowledgebase for key humanitarian information and analysis
2. Revising the way IM is governed
3. Systematizing the way innovation is spread and standards are set
4. Improving OCHA's IM capabilities
5. Enhancing OCHA's capacity to use technology to support its IM needs

Four of the five recommendations in this report are foundational and serve to enhance OCHA's ability to deliver the benefits of effective IM; without them substantial progress towards becoming an intellectual leader and knowledge broker is impossible. While they will benefit OCHA and its constituents, they will

do so indirectly. The first recommendation is a clear manifestation of OCHA's IM value and provides a tangible guiding principle for much of OCHA's IM work. We put it first because it is the most visible and profound difference OCHA can make to its many constituents.

4.2 Create an organization-wide cross-cluster knowledgebase for key humanitarian information and analysis

As the assessment portion of this report argues, OCHA has taken a “point solution” approach to IM. Individuals and groups have developed tools and IM products to address specific needs without necessarily thinking about how these tools and products work in the aggregate, or how they can benefit from the collective knowledge of OCHA and the broader humanitarian community. This practice has resulted in several IM deficiencies:

- OCHA's information resources are too often stored in silos across the organization (they sit in spreadsheets, HICs, Word documents, etc.) where they often go to waste.¹⁰

Even when this information is distributed – for instance in situation reports – it is very difficult to “unpack”. This is a crucial point. If one wants to understand the IDP situation in a particular country, one will often be forced to read several situation reports, it is unlikely that they would appear within the documents in the same place, and in fact, some reports might not mention IDPs at all. “Unpacking” this information is a laborious manual process – especially if one's aim is to analyze trends over time. Coming up with meaningful aggregates across districts, countries, or regions is generally both expensive and time consuming, if it can be done at all.

- OCHA has not standardized a set of humanitarian indicators that it tracks over time.¹¹ Values are collected haphazardly, and they may mean different things both across geographies and even across time (e.g., a country may report the same indicator differently depending on who is doing the reporting and when.)¹²
- OCHA has difficulty saying whether a humanitarian situation is improving or deteriorating over time and why. It also has difficulty knowing whether a situation in one location is better or worse than that in another.¹³
- Because of the lack of reliable humanitarian indicators and the information to support them, OCHA is perpetually reinventing the information wheel. Without a baseline to work from, it finds it difficult to improve its analysis of information as an organization.¹⁴

Sometimes when one mentions the need for standardizing the way information is collected, vetted, shared, analyzed, and distributed, the reaction is to say that all information is local and that standardization is a fool's errand. While it is true that one ignores local differences at one's peril, it is simply not true that effective standardized indicators and information practices are impossible to achieve. They can be

¹⁰ Silos can also cause confusion. In some cases the same document is stored in multiple locations. Situation reports are stored in FiDMS, in ODMS, and on ReliefWeb with the potential for various versions to co-exist at once. Interview with APIS and Alta Haggarty on August 18, 2007.

¹¹ This though ECHO proposed to set common humanitarian indicators for each cluster at the global level. See “Strengthening capacities for humanitarian information management and humanitarian classification systems.” The Echo Proposal at a Glance presented at the AIMB 2008 Work Planning offsite on August 22, 2007.

¹² Based on interviews with desk officers in CRD and field staff from OCHA, donors, and partners.

¹³ Based on interviews with desk officers in CRD and field staff from OCHA, donors, and partners.

¹⁴ There are instances where individual offices have created efficient information collection, vetting, analysis, and distribution apparatus, but these practices are isolated and not made available to OCHA as a whole.

achieved, and when done properly, they can radically change the value of an organization to its constituents.

One example of an organization using information in a game-changing way is the Food Security Analysis Unit (FSAU) for Somalia.¹⁵ FSAU has become *the* place to go to understand food issues in the region. The stature of FSAU is unimpeachable in the humanitarian community, and its data, maps, and analysis are widely used and quoted,

When FSAU was first proposed, there were many doubters. Because the situation in Somalia changed so often, indicators would be rendered invalid over time. Common indicators would not be useful because the different regions of Somalia were too varied in terms of geography, politics, and the types of crises they faced.

The naysayers have been proven wrong. The geographically and longitudinally based information, normalized in clear indicators and collected over 15 years, is proving invaluable to humanitarian workers across the country. Both the HC for Somalia, Eric LaRoche, and OCHA's HoO, Philippe Lazzarini, use the FSAU information to inform important decisions that they make. Has nutrition improved over the past 15 years of humanitarian action in Somalia? FSAU can provide the information to make an evidenced-based determination and suggest further action.¹⁶

FSAU was not an overnight success. It took time to incrementally improve its indicators and analysis and to develop its network of sources (over 100 people both inside and outside of FSAU help it collect information). The cost was not insignificant. But success has been its own reward. A virtuous cycle has been achieved so that as FSAU provides valuable information and analysis to partners and donors, they become more apt to provide FSAU with useful information, thus further improving FSAU's information and analysis, and so on.¹⁷

The World Bank's Doing Business Project is another good example. It "provides objective measures of business regulations and their enforcement" globally.¹⁸ The team [of over 40 economists] works closely with "more than 4,400 lawyers, judges, business people and public officials in 175 countries around the world."¹⁹ It is the gold standard for understanding development from a private sector point-of-view. It has firmly established the World Bank as the leading authority in this field. For instance, *The Economist* has referenced the Doing Business Project in hundreds of articles over the years.

Like FSAU, the Doing Business Project collects, vets, analyzes, and distributes information used for decision making. It also makes this information available so that users can do their own analysis. It provides a powerful and supple information network for the development world.

Could OCHA do the same sort of thing for cross-cluster information designed for the humanitarian community? The IM Review Team believes not only that it can, but that such an information network is a part of its mandate.

This type of work is not alien to OCHA; some of its leading offices are already doing it. For instance, oPt's Protection of Civilians database contains indicators -- quantifiable data -- collected over several years that monitors casualties, property demolitions, land leveling, and access.

¹⁵ <http://www.fsasomali.org/index.html>

¹⁶ The answer is no, and this despite more food being made available over time.

¹⁷ Interestingly, the same model used by FSAU is now being applied in Burundi, where the effort is starting to have success. The project there has met with the same set of objections about the applicability of common standard indicators as did FSAU. ECHO is looking to spread this model to other countries as well.

¹⁸ <http://www.doingbusiness.org/>

¹⁹ <http://www.doingbusiness.org/LocalPartners/>

Not only is this type of knowledgebase familiar to OCHA, it already has a potential channel for its output: ReliefWeb. According to its homepage, “ReliefWeb is the global hub for time-critical humanitarian information on Complex Emergencies and Natural Disasters.” While ReliefWeb is a respected and often used tool, it has not come close to achieving its full potential. Currently, it is a repository of documents classified in a fixed hierarchy. It could be much more. ReliefWeb could become *the* humanitarian community’s center for data, interactive maps, simulations, financial information, practitioner discussion, and analysis. (The Doing Business project’s home page provides a good model for how this might look, see Figure 2: The World Bank's "Doing Business" Home Page.)

This recommendation is not merely about revamping ReliefWeb. It is about completely revamping OCHA’s IM practices, content, and tools. Ultimately, the knowledgebase could become the foundation for a more robust knowledge management practice that OCHA could offer both externally and internally.

Doing Business

The Doing Business project...

provides objective measures of business regulations and their enforcement across 175 countries. The team works closely with thousands of professionals around the world.



Doing Business is a guide...

for evaluating regulations that directly impact economic growth, downloading underlying laws, making cross-country comparisons, and identifying good practice reforms.

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Doing Business Map: With the click of a mouse, policy makers and investors worldwide can see how difficult it is to do business in 175 countries using a new interactive map powered by Google. The map complements the Bank Group's flagship annual report on Doing Business by displaying key information on ease of doing business. The color coding of economies helps communicate the key messages of the report.



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- ▶ Ranking simulator: See the impact of reforms by using the ranking simulator and test the impact of reforms

Simulate reforms

How would a country's ranking change if it reformed? See the impact of reforms by using the ranking simulator (Excel, 186KB) to change indicator values. This exercise assumes that other countries don't reform.

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Figure 2: The World Bank's "Doing Business" Home Page

What we are proposing is that *every* OCHA IM product used to support OCHA’s coordination role be purposed to meet the humanitarian community’s need for a central and authoritative source with a global perspective on humanitarian response. This means that whenever an IM product is created or updated—whether situation reports, 3W, HICs, CAPs, or FTS—it should by default be designed to feed into OCHA’s cross-cluster knowledgebase of indicators and analyses.

Ultimately, the sum of OCHA’s collective knowledge should flow into this, so that it becomes *the* authoritative source and collective record for the humanitarian community. Information “islands” would be systematically eliminated. *OCHA would become an information-focused, not a tool-based, organization.*

With this visible, well-managed, and comprehensive online resource, OCHA could legitimately demonstrate intellectual leadership within the humanitarian community because it would have the relationships, the information, analysis, and communication skills to underpin that position. Properly done, this repository could dramatically improve OCHA’s reputation and brand promise to the world. *It would become a constantly appreciating knowledge asset.*

Turning this concept into reality will be no minor feat. But this type of online resource could provide the organizing principle for all of OCHA’s outward-facing IM activities (one that OCHA currently lacks.)

The next sections details the changes to governance, innovation, standards practices, capabilities, and technology that will be required to improve OCHA’s IM performance and that will, if OCHA decides to take it on, allow the knowledgebase to become a reality.

4.3 Revise the Way IM Is Governed

Effective oversight of information management is the single most important predictor for creating value. IM oversight is an executive management responsibility. If IM is not generating value, executive management should first examine its oversight practices. No organization with which the IM Review Team is familiar – *not one* – has created and sustained a successful IM program without substantial executive management involvement in its oversight.²⁰

OCHA's oversight, compared with other organizations we have surveyed (including other humanitarian organizations, professional services firms, and energy companies) is better than some, but nowhere close to the leaders or at an optimal level. To improve oversight of IM, we recommend that the Senior Management Team (SMT) take the following actions:

- Establish a vision for IM
- Establish a set of IM guidelines that support OCHA's IM vision
- Create an IM Governance Team that would oversee
 - A set of five product portfolios to support user needs
 - A set of IM services that would support the product portfolios

4.3.1 IM Vision

Since the IM Review started, John Holmes has articulated a clear 5-year vision for OCHA which includes aspects related to information management. To paraphrase, it is:

***OCHA will be an intellectual leader and knowledge broker
for the humanitarian community***

This vision, while ambitious, is in the estimation of the IM Review Team both desirable and achievable. We have aligned our recommendations to promote it.

4.3.2 IM Guidelines

If the ability to successfully coordinate humanitarian response relies on providing insight for decision making, then everyone at OCHA should understand that his/her job is helping to provide stakeholders with the right information at the right time and to take advantage of available information to make evidenced-based decisions. Senior management should encourage an “information culture” in OCHA – one that highly values the sharing and use of information. OCHA should aspire to what the consulting firm McKinsey calls its “100% cubed” policy: 100% of stakeholders should receive 100% of the organization's relevant information and insight 100% of the time.

There are more specific guidelines that, if spelled out and encouraged by senior management, would help OCHA to excel in its role as primary information broker to the humanitarian community. The authors suggest that these guidelines be promoted by senior management and applied when designing and producing *every* OCHA IM product and service:

1. **Every IM product is part of a managed portfolio.** OCHA can no longer afford to use a point solution approach to developing its IM products. Such an approach produces a

²⁰ Bruce Strong, Thomas Davenport, Larry Prusak, “Organizational Governance of Knowledge and Learning,” article to be published in the *Wall Street Journal*.

confusing set of non-interoperable products to the target audience and is inefficient. Before an IM product is initiated, it should be approved by the business owner (not an IT person), who will take into account how that product fits within the “product catalog” for the target audience. Clear roles and responsibilities in terms of decision-making (accountable, responsible, and contributor), work hand-offs, and portfolio change control and improvements must be established for each target audience.

2. **Each information category (domain) has a designated owner.** OCHA needs to collect, vet, share, and analyze information in a consistent way. OCHA has several domains of common interest that it must take into account in the work it does, for example, disasters, countries, and directories of OCHA employees, donors, and partners. Currently, these information categories are defined in an uncoordinated way, making finding and understanding information difficult.²¹ The information category owner would be responsible for the definitions of the category, including the required attributes that describe it. This owner would also be responsible for the integrity of the information.
3. **Unconnected information islands should be avoided** Whenever a non-administrative IM product is created or updated it should by default be designed to become part of the common knowledgebase. The sum of OCHA’s collective knowledge should be connected so that anyone who needs to use it can easily do so. OCHA’s emphasis should be on becoming an information-focused, not a tool-based, organization.
4. **When practical, the unit of analysis should be information, not documents.** Embedding information in documents makes it difficult to unpack. Especially indicators, when placed in different parts of a document, are hard to find and use across documents. Information should be structured so that it is easy to manipulate electronically. For instance, IDP figures are often embedded within situation reports, making aggregation and comparisons impossible without manual intervention.
5. **Information – normalized and with clear provenance – is collected only once and re-used as necessary.** Data normalization ensures that OCHA can do “apples to apples” comparisons. For instance, IDP counts from DRC could be easily and accurately compared with those from Sudan, and comparative trends between regions could be monitored over time so as to measure and influence IDP-related decisions. Information should only be entered once for efficiency and then reused by different applications as required. Currently this type of information repurposing does not always happen. And the information needs to be attributable to its source so that its reliability can be judged (this is especially important because much of the information OCHA receives is from outside its control.)²²
6. **IM is seamlessly embedded into OCHA’s practices.** Embedding is important to OCHA primarily because it ensures the information is easily available and can be applied to

²¹ For instance, there are redundant country profiles being maintained by a number of sections, including Emergency Preparedness, Environmental Emergencies, Public Information, ReliefWeb, GCMS, and External and Donor Relations. These each have a different focus, but there are common data elements that all could share. Likewise, several directories are maintained across OCHA that store redundant information, including the Central Registry, 3W, GDACS, ERP white pages, and many spreadsheets.

²² For instance, the information in situation reports is often not easily traced to its source by anyone other than the author of the report. (Obviously, in certain cases, sources will need to be protected and cannot be revealed.)

critical thinking in decision-making. If it is embedded in practice, OCHA benefits in three ways: First, if collecting, creating, sharing, and using information are considered to be integral to a person's job, then s/he is likely to attach importance to these tasks. Second, in an emergency, IM practices that are embedded into the way people do their work will tend to be easily used despite time constraints. Third, given OCHA's high rate of turnover and need to quickly bring new personnel onboard, embedding IM into work creates the ability to learn by doing the job rather than by extensive classroom-type training.²³

7. **Information can be easily manipulated and viewed in ways that make sense to OCHA's stakeholders.** There are a finite number of priority information categories (domains) (e.g., region, country, disaster, donor, cluster) that are of interest to OCHA stakeholders. Information should be stored and structured so that it can be easily found and repurposed into different "views." For instance, the same body of information could be used to view which donors participated in helping a country over time or easily formatted to show which countries a particular donor funded.

4.3.3 IM Product Portfolio Approach

OCHA should assign a single point-of-accountability for each one of its five key portfolios of products: advocacy, coordination, funding, internal communications, and policy. In addition to these five portfolio owners, there should also be an overall portfolio coordinator for *all* of OCHA's IM products and services to ensure that the entire portfolio is on point strategically, to maintain overall interoperability, and to ensure that the portfolio is balanced across stakeholders in terms of resource investment against priorities. It is these portfolio owners who would be responsible for assessing user needs and making sure that they were being met.

Our assessment indicates that no *one* person is responsible for meeting the information needs of each key stakeholder group. Furthermore, there is no role at OCHA that systematically assesses the impact of the products and services on key audience needs or expectations, let alone whether they do or do not further the strategic objectives of the organization. Interviews uncovered critical needs that could be addressed by a portfolio approach:

- **Stakeholder product and service catalogs.** During our interviews, partners and donors were unable to identify all of the products that OCHA produces or where to find such a list. Likewise, field staff, including Information Management Officers, expressed their desire for a product catalog. Like any organization that provides services, OCHA should present its stakeholders with an easily understood and accessible catalog of its products. This includes understanding what stakeholder information needs are and meeting them.
- **Improved interoperability.** A portfolio approach would further help to ensure that OCHA's IM products were consistent and efficient to use and maintain. Currently, there are significant redundancies and information sharing and integrity issues. For instance,

²³ Think of ordering a book on amazon.com. Policies and procedures are "embedded" into your interaction with the application. You can use certain types of credit cards, your address must match the one on your credit card, etc. Amazon never sends out a manual with policies and procedures – they are embedded. This "no training" model should become aspirational for many of OCHA's IM applications.

there are at least five different types of country profiles being maintained in OCHA, none of which are formally synchronized.²⁴

- **Better sharing of best practices.** A portfolio approach would allow for more sharing of best practices among the builders and users of the portfolio's products. For instance, Information Management Officers in the field feel that their efforts would significantly benefit from having a forum where they could exchange best practices. Their last meeting in Kristinehamn, Sweden revealed several examples where products and practices used in individual field offices could greatly benefit other offices as well.

4.3.4 IM Services Approach

OCHA's IM could be better supported by a well-managed infrastructure of shared services, some technical, some not. Examples of these services include search facilities, usability testing services, controlled vocabularies and metadata management services, evaluation tools and metrics to measure user satisfaction, and information category (domain) management,. Most of these services are currently provided as one-offs for specific products.

Some specific examples of OCHA-wide IM services that do not yet exist or could be improved include:

- Meta-data management (the taxonomy used to describe information) does not have a designated owner who is accountable to a work plan.
- Until recently, there were several OCHA Websites using different search mechanisms. None was seen as being very effective even though each was created at considerable expense. ITS is now rolling out a single search facility that will work across multiple websites including ReliefWeb, OCHA Online, the Intranet and Field Office Websites. Ideally, search will become a service that could be leveraged with every new product at no or low incremental cost. With a consistent search service, end-users would be much more likely to find the information they are looking for and to be aware of the information available to them.
- No one is responsible for the overall visual design and presentation of OCHA's IM products and services as they appear to internal and external audiences such as the branding that exists on OCHA Online, the Intranet, the Annual Report, and the Field Websites.
- Some services are simply missing, such as user research (what do users want?) and Web analytics (what do user usage patterns tell you about a situation?²⁵).

IM Services oversight logically belongs with the Advocacy and Information Management Branch. The Branch Head would be accountable for the effective and efficient planning, implementation, management, and continuous improvement of the services across all of OCHA. These services should enable OCHA to deliver on its strategic objectives and therefore should support those objectives as prioritized by the Senior Management Team.

²⁴ There are country profiles being maintained by a number of sections, including Emergency Preparedness, Environmental Emergencies, Public Information, ReliefWeb, GCMS, and External and Donor Relations. These all have a different focus, but there are common data elements that each can share.

²⁵ ReliefWeb is starting to use Web analytics to understand changes in a country. For instance, if all of a sudden Burundi has many security officer vacancies, does this mean that there is a looming security crisis?

4.3.5 IM Governance Team

To pull each of these functions together, we are recommending the creation of an IM Governance Team. The purpose of the team is to allow for a conversation to occur within and across OCHA's IM product portfolios and IM services. It would help to rationalize which IM products are produced and how they are subsequently developed, maintained, evaluated, and budgeted. This is a conversation that rarely happens in OCHA's current point solution paradigm. Another key goal of the IM Governance Team is to create an integrated view of its IM activities. This view will allow management to know:

- What IM products and services OCHA is producing
- How effective they are
- How much they cost

Please see Figure 3: Graphic Representation of IM Governance Team for a description of how the IM Governance Team is structured. For a description of the illustrated roles, see section 5.1 Decision Points.

Figure SEQ Figure * ARABIC 3: Graphic Representation of IM Governance Team

4.4 Systematize the way innovation is spread, maintenance is outsourced, and standards are set

In this section, we discuss the relationship between innovation and standards in the context of OCHA's IM practices.

4.4.1 Innovation

Innovation is a strategic imperative for OCHA. Externally, the world is in constant flux. The number and types of humanitarian crises OCHA must address is constantly changing. Internally, OCHA's mandate is constantly evolving as well. Support for the humanitarian reform and OCHA's new role as a manager of very large pool funds are two examples of profound change.

For OCHA, doing things the same way today as it did yesterday is not a viable option. This situation begs the question, if OCHA needs to innovate, what will be the source of innovation?

OCHA is blessed with an exceptionally entrepreneurial culture. OCHA employees working at the coal face – those working directly with partners and donors – bring a great deal of imagination (not to mention determination) to solving real problems.

From an IM perspective, OCHA generally does a poor job of harnessing the imagination of its staff.²⁶ At best, innovations (whether they are from the front office or the field) are not spread across the organization as best practices. At worst, innovators are branded as mavericks who “don't follow the rules” and need to be suppressed.

Both senior management and AIMB (including ITS) are sometimes focused on the wrong areas. Figure 4: OCHA IM Portfolio Attention Map²⁷ may provide a useful model for considering how OCHA should view every IM project it undertakes. Each quadrant is described with examples from OCHA:

- **Quadrant I: Productive Projects.** Projects in Quadrant I both are strategic and have senior management buy-in and attention. A good example is the Policy & Guidance project led by PDSB.
- **Quadrant II: Misconceived Projects.** Projects in Quadrant II are misconceived in that they are maintenance (i.e., not innovative) in nature and they occupy senior management attention. Given OCHA's innovation imperative, senior management should minimize its attention spent on these types of projects. The Situation Report Update project, as currently conceived, is one such project. Its goal is to make situation reports more predictable and useful by providing clear templates and guidelines for their production. These are useful goals, but not really innovative. In the appendix for the situation report, the IM Review recommends that the Update project be made more innovative (and hence a Quadrant I project) by changing situation reports into an electronic form that would radically change the way information is collected, vetted, analyzed, and reported by OCHA.

²⁶ This state of affairs doesn't exist only in OCHA. Many public- and private-sector organizations we have worked with have the same issues.

²⁷ The Portfolio Attention Map is a tool that will be more fully described in a upcoming book entitled *Strategic Conversations*, JC Spender, Bruce Strong, Mary Lee Kennedy.

- Quadrant III: Opportunities for Outsourcing.** For an organization whose imperative is innovation, maintenance activities should always be candidates for outsourcing. Management, and for that matter staff, do not have the time to pay attention to maintenance activities. The hosting of ReliefWeb used to be in Quadrant III. OCHA at one time actually housed and maintained these servers on premises. This activity is now outsourced (and hence no longer appears on OCHA's Attention Map). Applications programming is another prime candidate for outsourcing. For OCHA, programming is not a core competence. As long as OCHA's ITS group is able to manage outsourced programmers well (i.e., it has a clear IT architecture and application development methodology), the programming itself could be outsourced.

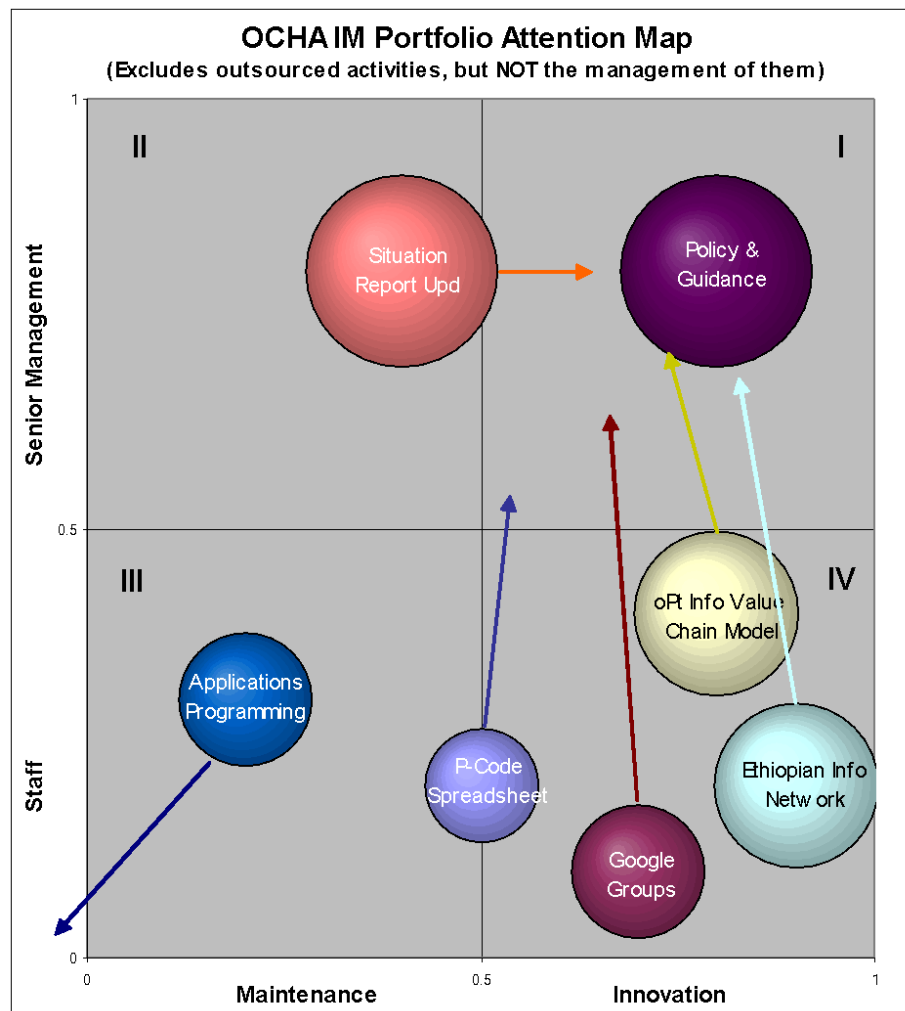


Figure SEQ Figure 1* ARABIC 4: OCHA IM Portfolio Attention Map

- Quadrant IV: Missed Opportunities for Innovation.** The IM Review Team has observed that there is a breakdown in “conversation” between those working with partners and donors (staff) and those who set policy at the organizational level (senior management.) Too often a field office engages in an innovation in isolation that could, if promoted by management, benefit the rest of the organization. Examples, illustrated in

Quadrant IV of the map, are the information value chain used by oPt to create actionable protection information, Uganda's use of a collaboration tool, Google Groups, to create a robust community of partners in the Gulu area, Ethiopia's systematic creation of a network of information gatherers that makes the OCHA office the hub of information for the humanitarian community, and even a spreadsheet developed in Nepal that is profoundly useful for assigning village names to mapping coordinates. These are all instances in which the focus of these innovative conversations – best practices that should be spread throughout the organization – should move from staff to senior management. These projects should move from Quadrant IV to Quadrant I.

As noted by numerous scholars of innovation, the most difficult thing for an organization to do is to become aware of the important innovation generated by their staff and then to operationalize it throughout the organization.²⁸ The IM Review Team has encountered at least two areas within OCHA that could be effective promoters of local IM innovation to the organization as a whole:

1. **Regional offices** have a unique perspective on what works and does not work at the local level. They are able to see patterns invisible to both country offices below and senior management above. It might be useful to have innovation discovery as part of their terms of reference.
2. **AIMB** has convocation power for all of the Information Management Officers across OCHA. It should listen for innovations and act to promote them by helping to make them more robust, easier to distribute, and, when appropriate, standardized.

4.4.2 Standardization

Standardization and innovation are closely related. Standards provide the baseline upon which sustained organizational innovation can be built. Standards, properly implemented, advance useful creativity and innovation. Without standards, staff may be creative about the format they use in a situation report or the set of menus they use in a field Web site, but if people across the organization are all “being creative,” this is really wasted effort and a lost opportunity to leverage proven practices. Good standards will establish a clear and useful template so that staff members can focus their creative energies on what really matters, the content.

Without standards, how do you know you're actually innovating? What's the baseline for improvement? *And how does the organization benefit from innovation unless it standardizes upon it?* Without standards – and this is the case at OCHA – employees improvise solutions, but they cannot really create sustainable innovation.

The ability to innovate in impactful ways is enabled by standards – and seriously hindered by the lack thereof. In their adoption, standards facilitate the realization of other benefits. For example:

- **Standards facilitate effective decentralization.** Because OCHA is geographically distributed across the globe, much of the work that it does needs to be managed in a decentralized way. Individuals in the field reacting to an emergency situation cannot wait for HQ to make decisions on the ground. Field offices require a great deal of autonomy to react to the particulars of their situations.

²⁸ See Ikujiro Nonaka, “The Knowledge Creating Company,” Harvard Business Review, November-December 1991 and Doz, Santos, and Williamson From Global to Metanational, Harvard Business School Press, 2001.

In such an environment, standards and commonly understood practices are important. The relation between decentralization and standards is paradoxical. The more decentralized an organization is, the more it needs standards if it is to provide consistent and coherent benefits to its stakeholders. Thomas Malone of MIT puts it this way: *“Rigid standards in the right parts of a system can enable much more flexibility and decentralization in other parts of the system.”*²⁹

Having standards on how key functions are performed and how events are reported – and having these standards and practices widely understood and adhered to – allows senior management to effectively manage even when decisions are locally made.³⁰ Standards determine what the key outputs should be, their quality, and how they should be reported. This enables management to more easily understand and aggregate information about performance across many decentralized units. Because standards provide a common vocabulary for describing a situation, they also allow local OCHA responders to leverage the work of others, quickly understand the context of an emergency, and communicate their information rapidly.

- **Standards create predictability and reliability.** OCHA currently has a large set of Websites. There is no overall common look and feel among these sites nor any organized relationship between their content. For an individual or organization that needs to engage with OCHA, it is very difficult to know all of what OCHA offers. Standards for Web products and services would remove this unnecessary barrier to OCHA.

Without clarity about information gathering methods, the common application of those methods, and shared practices for assessing successes and failures, endless hours are spent putting together trends reporting for senior managers. One of the more senior analysts at OCHA expressed significant frustration with this situation, because not only was time wasted in mundane, manual efforts trying to make sense of information, but no one could be found to be held accountable for meeting any standard. This individual cannot depend on the work of others. On the other hand, the work of UNHCR has resulted in predictable and reliable protection numbers, as well as respected demographic information.

- **Standards promote efficiency.** The Strategic Planning Unit fundamentally seeks to ensure the organization is focused on those efforts that matter most, and then to connect wherever possible related pieces of work to drive efficiencies in the organization. This analogy can be applied to information as well. The object is to ensure that the information and the knowledge of the organization can be applied to those matters that are most important, and that this application is achieved as efficiently as possible. An example of problematic application is highlighted by the Situation Reports, which are deposited in

²⁹ Thomas Malone, *The Future of Work*, Harvard Business School Press, 2004, p. 133.

³⁰ OCHA has several models to consider in evaluating the benefits derived from standards in other decentralized efforts. The Refugee Standards and Indicators adopted by the UNHCR allow them the opportunity to monitor what they are doing, and they believe they will eventually increase their funding. UNGIWG as an informal group of individuals and agencies seeks to formalize their organization focused on the creation of data standards, the facilitation of an exchange of information whether it is technical, procedural and maybe even about services. They are inspired by the work of the groups such as INSPIRE coming out of the European Union.

FiDMS, ReliefWeb and in ODMS according to each repository's standards. In fact each repository has managed its own meta-data without regard to other meta-data (such as that being developed by PDSB), thus making it very difficult to find the information if one is not sure in which repository it resides.

An example of where standards do improve efficiency is the CAP. Here the efforts to standardize the process have increased the efficiency with which proposals are assessed. Here as well, the CAP Section is well aware of the need for even more standards to drive greater efficiencies.

In a more efficient environment, the content would be deposited in one format that could then be presented in different views according to audience needs. The content itself would be managed to an agreed-upon standard template for information storage and would be versioned over time to show the context within which it was constructed.

4.4.3 The Art of Setting Standards

These examples argue that it is incumbent upon OCHA to become adept at developing, coordinating, and promulgating standards. To do so, standards bodies within OCHA should remember that: **An effective standards body is the steward, and *not* the owner, of the standards it produces. The owners of the standards are those entities to which the standards apply.**

The implications of this statement are essential. In adopting this fundamental principle, we believe, OCHA will be more effective at setting standards. For instance, field staff fear standards coming out of HQ that “are the lowest common denominator” and that “stifle creativity and innovation.” Many field staff expressed their opinion that standards are imposed by HQ in the absence of a good understanding of their situation.³¹ As there is no sense of ownership of standards in the field, there is no widespread adherence to them. Where there is adherence, HQ is forced to expend a great deal of energy to gain compliance.³²

In order for OCHA to be an effective standards steward, HQ standards stewards will need to learn how to facilitate standards creation, maintenance, and exceptions processes.³³ Only then will OCHA be able to efficiently understand stakeholder needs, facilitate compromise, and serve as a midwife for creating solutions that serve the community to which the standards will apply. This process requires expertise in standards stewardship. Standards-setting is notoriously difficult and tedious. Nonetheless, even fiercely competing organizations – such as Microsoft, Sun Microsystems, and IBM – have agreed to standards created by neutral standards bodies, because the standards benefit everyone.

³¹ Much of this information came out of a standards presentation given by one of the IM Review Team's members in Sweden.

³² For instance, we know of at least one field office that dutifully used the OCHA field Web template in order to satisfy a mandate from FIS, but then created a parallel Web site in its own format that it actively maintained.

³³ A well-defined exceptions process is required for innovation.

4.5 Enhance OCHA's capacity to use technology to support its IM needs

While the focus of this review is information management and how it should be used to help provide insight for decision making, information technology is a key enabler for IM and must be addressed.

In our interactions with IT staff, the IM Review Team has been impressed by their competence and dedication. Nonetheless, IT at OCHA is not as effective as it could be. On the basis of our assessment, we believe that there are opportunities to do the following:

- Improve OCHA's IT architecture to make IM applications easier to create and less costly to maintain
- Improve OCHA's application development process
- Reduce IT resource bottlenecks through outsourcing
- Make the field the progenitor of field applications and FIS their steward
- Have ITS help measure the value of IT investments

4.5.1 Improve OCHA's IT Architecture

As mentioned earlier, OCHA is a young organization that has gone through significant growth. Thus, until recently there has not been time to enforce an enterprise IT strategy. Nonetheless, OCHA is at a threshold moment. **In order to support the complexity of its own operations and, as required, to support the humanitarian community, it must create a sustainable and reliable IT architectural platform that makes applications easier to build and maintain and supports interoperability among them.**

A plethora of technologies are now being used that make application development and maintenance unnecessarily expensive, complex, and slow:

- ReliefWeb is built using multiple Lotus Notes databases and a Domino front end
- OCHAOnline and the Intranet are built with Lotus Notes forms for loading content, SQL backend databases to store content, and Dot Net Nuke to publish pages
- 3W is built on yet another platform (known to only one or two people)
- The OSOCC is built on an Access platform
- HICs have been built on several different technology platforms

ITS is now taking concerted steps to consolidate and rationalize OCHA's IT architecture. One key step was adopting a common search technology that is now used for ReliefWeb, OCHA Online, and the Intranet. This approach will reduce maintenance and development costs, will make finding support expertise easier, and will provide better service to users.³⁴ Even though it took a long time to implement (in part because it needed to support so many different platforms), it was the right move at the right time.

³⁴ One key example of how adopting a common search engine will help is synonym rings, which allow a user to enter the phrase "Internally Displaced Persons" or "IDP" and receive the same set of results. This type of "fit and finish" is generally only affordable if leveraged by many different applications.

OCHA has begun to empower its ITS Chief to make enterprise architectural decisions – another correct step. While the ITS Chief should solicit input, one person needs to be responsible for the architecture’s success or failure. Architecture by committee is not a recipe for success.

Nonetheless, this empowerment has not yet fully taken hold. The decision to use a technology called Dot Net Nuke to support the content management and Web publishing needs of OCHA Online and the Intranet was made by a consultant in New York without sufficient discussion with the ITS Chief. For various reasons, may not have been a good decision.³⁵

The previous recommendation notwithstanding, while the ITS Chief needs to be empowered to make decisions, s/he should not do so in a vacuum. Progressive organizations now insist that senior management exercise its management role in architectural decisions that can have profound cost and functionality implications for years. Senior management should require that the ITS Chief present *options* and *tradeoffs* that explain the implications of architectural decisions from a business perspective. Furthermore, senior management should be accountable for establishing the priorities and focus areas that the ITS Chief needs to support.

Currently, this is not the case at OCHA. The ITS Chief is not having a conversation with the senior management team, which both weakens the ITS Chief and takes the senior management team out of key strategic decisions.³⁶

ITS will be recommending that a neutral (i.e., no technology vendor bias) consultancy – Gartner Inc. – evaluate OCHA’s technical architecture and suggest an enterprise approach. This makes sense. OCHA does need to update its architecture – the current platform will not serve its needs – and this will be neither easy nor inexpensive. There is little room for error because architectural decisions have long-term cost and functionality implications.

Using an outside consultancy makes sense in another way. The Gartner Group can and should be tasked with presenting a clear business (as opposed to technical) case for their recommendations – and present options in terms of cost, time, and functionality that should make sense to OCHA’s senior management team, thus allowing both the ITS Chief and the SMT to make informed decisions for actions that will have long term implications for OCHA’s ability to achieve its IM vision.

The IM Review Team recommends that the Gartner report address the five main architectural needs facing OCHA today:

1. Archiving and document management
2. Collaboration (sharing documents and calendars, discussion groups)
3. Collaboration (simultaneous work on documents)
4. Simple content publishing
5. Work-flow-driven content publishing

³⁵ Dot Net Nuke has not worked well in the field, has been difficult to integrate with OCHA’s tools such as FIDIMS, and is not a commonly used tool outside of OCHA (which makes finding Dot Net Nuke programmers difficult).

³⁶ Using the innovation model discussed earlier -- Figure 4: OCHA IM Portfolio Attention Map – current architectural decisions are stuck largely in quadrant IV (innovation only discussed at the staff level), whereas they should be in quadrant I (innovation fully discussed at the senior management level.)

Archiving and document management. OCHA field offices and HQ need a generally accessible place to put their working documents for archival purposes. OCHA staff need to be able to find documents created by their colleagues past and present. These archives, when it is easy to add and retrieve documents, can form an important part of OCHA's organizational memory.

OCHA is using Lotus Notes for storage and access for native documentation that is created both at headquarters and in the field. Currently there are 30-40,000 documents stored in two primary Lotus Notes databases: FiDMS for documents created and stored by field offices, and ODMS for documents created and stored by HQ.

Some of the issues that should be addressed by the Gartner report are:

- **Document standardization.** The documents stored are fairly standardized by type (such as situation reports), and the individual types of documents are limited in number. The documents could lend themselves to further structuring and standardization.
- **Taxonomy.** A taxonomy is reflected in the metadata on the Notes document entry screens and in the way that the files are presented via the browse interface. There are two issues here
 1. The taxonomy has not kept pace with changes in the organization. It was conceived about three years ago and has a top-down, HQ-driven flavor; there is currently no mechanism for updating the taxonomy with "bottom-up" changes or contributions from the field. OCHA staff recognize that there needs to be a mechanism for taxonomy to evolve with the organization and that taxonomy changes should reflect work in the field rather than top-down organizational structure.
 2. One strength of Lotus Notes over other document management systems that rely on file systems is the dynamic nature of the classification schemes. Single instances of documents can occur in multiple lists, allowing browse access to the same document in multiple ways. This strength is undermined by the fact that the metadata elements that are used at document check-in are too numerous and not intuitive. Often, users simply upload the document without completing the metadata, resulting in incomplete forms and ultimately unclassified, poorly described documents that are difficult or impossible to find. Because the taxonomy is lengthy, multi-hierarchical, and non-intuitive, using it as a browse structure for locating documents is frustrating and often unsuccessful.

ITS and FIS should work with their respective users to come up with a very simple taxonomy that is both intuitive and useful. As a standard, it should be designed and approved by the people it affects. It may also be useful to allow for local extensions of the standard taxonomy to address local needs.³⁷

- **Connectivity.** Any document contribution and consumption solution should consider the different connectivity and bandwidth for users at different locations. The solution should not be designed to serve only the lowest common denominator; it should allow for

³⁷ It would probably make sense to base the taxonomy on the branch, section, or country to which a document belonged. Our intuition is that this will be the most common way that documents will be searched.

limited connectivity for those in the deep field and take advantage of good connectivity for those at HQ and some country offices.

- **Use Analytics.** There are little or no analytics for documents stored in Lotus Notes. Some amount of user analytics that indicate how users are browsing, searching for, and using documents would be helpful in determining optimal browse structures and which documents are most important to users.

Collaboration (sharing documents and calendars, discussion groups). Potential for collaboration comes from inside and outside OCHA, and much of the Web publishing effort is directed toward making documentation widely available across OCHA and to partners and donors. The flow of information goes two ways, with OCHA distributing information to and receiving information from the outside. There is a general recognition that this two-way sharing of information needs to be easier, with better capabilities for partners and donors to contribute documents to OCHA.

The IM Review Team would in general suggest moving away from Web publishing (other than Wikis) for collaboration purposes. Web publishing tools are too heavy, and generally require intermediation from OCHA to work, thus reducing the ability to do real collaboration since partners and donors cannot add their own documents.

OCHA should consider using a neutral forum like Google Groups. This is done in several field offices, and in Uganda, the Gulu region has over 250 active users. OCHA acts as moderator, but members can easily post documents at their convenience. Discussion groups and calendar functions are also available.

Collaboration (simultaneous work on documents). Currently, OCHA does not support simultaneous work on documents. It should. IM products such as the CAP and Policies and Guidelines would benefit from the ability of multiple users to work on the same document at roughly the same time without fear of overwriting one another and without the hassle of multiple versions being sent by email.

Using Wikis for more real-time collaboration could be considered and would move the organization away from strictly document-based sharing of information.

Simple Content Publishing. Simple Web publishing at OCHA is in the form of a donor and stakeholder site (CERF), an intranet, a public-facing internet (OCHA Online), and approximately 15 field portals running on the Dot Net Nuke platform. The sites are used to push native documentation (which often begins life as Word documents stored in FiDMS or ODMS) to all parts of OCHA and beyond, specifically to the New York and Geneva offices, OCHA country and field offices, partners in relief organizations, and the general public.

Transfer of documents from ODMS or FiDMS to the SQL databases for Web publishing is problematical and requires technical workarounds. Specifically, there is a concern that the combination of Lotus Notes and Dot Net Nuke is not the right platform for long-term growth and flexibility. There is consensus on the need for a stable, seamlessly integrated platform for document management, collaboration, and Web publishing rather than the piecemeal integration and workarounds that are currently in place. Ease of administration, standards for publishing, and end-user acceptance are paramount.

Commercial applications compatible with OCHA's choice of SQLServer as the backend database exist, such as SharePoint. For branch or field Web sites, or for the Intranet, software such as SharePoint allows the IT group to develop sophisticated templates that can then be used by less systems savvy users to create effective and attractive Web pages. Applications such as SharePoint are much more commonly used than Dot Net Nuke, and therefore have the advantage of a larger programmer community and are more robust.

Work-flow-driven publishing.

IRIN and ReliefWeb are examples of professional, work-flow-driven Web publishing done at OCHA.

While the IM Review Team did not investigate IRIN, it did collect considerable background on ReliefWeb. ReliefWeb uses Lotus Notes Domino for Web publishing. Publication of the site is on a rolling basis, with updates occurring in Geneva, New York, and Kobe, Japan daily. Because of the 24-hour nature of the updates, there are numerous handoffs between the offices as one office closes and another opens.

There is general concern, however, that the platform is not keeping pace with both technological advances for information publishing and OCHA's general publishing needs. The ReliefWeb team has developed SOPs around the Domino platform, but feels the need to take advantage of other available technology as well.

Issues and challenges associated with the publishing of the site include:

- Need to integrate other languages beginning with French and Spanish and extending to the other main UN languages as necessary.
- Need better metadata and business rules to smooth the promotion and publication of content from the Notes databases.
- Too much time is being spent on minor content changes or technical issues such as simple changes to the home page or the authoring of vacancy announcements.
- Need to have the capability to immediately post content (some of this is procedural, but the current technology also does not support the effort).
- No mechanism to preview content before it is published.
- Locating content in the databases, monitoring sources of content and feeds, and getting content posted to the site are all cumbersome.
- Need the site to be mirrored around the world for better connectivity and redundancy.
- Need additional work and testing to optimize the site for search engines; currently using Google analytics for assessing user behavior on the site.

A considerable amount of work has been done in defining business requirements. The requirements now need to be assessed against the current publishing platform and other Web content management and publishing systems.

Many of the issues listed could be addressed with an enterprise-level content management system (CMS) with full functionality including workflow, preview, authoring systems, design templates, and distributed content. A potential CMS candidate would be Documentum, given its implementation in other areas of the UN.

Architectural Issues Summary

These are some of the key architectural issues facing OCHA's ITS group today.³⁸ A summary of the needs, and sample (not recommended) solutions, is provided in the table below:

Need	Sample Technology Solution	Comments
Archiving, document management	FIDMS or ODMS	The current Lotus Notes-based technology may make sense since it works well in both high- and low-bandwidth situations and presents data (through the use of views) in a way that is useful to users.
Collaboration (sharing documents and calendars, discussion groups)	Google Groups	With some modifications to Google Groups (which Google may very well be willing to do), could provide a flexible, simple, and non-OCHA-directed way to share information among partners and donors.
Collaboration (simultaneous work on documents)	Wikis	Working on documents simultaneously (instead of serially, and via email) would have many advantages for OCHA. Development time for SOPs or CAPs could be reduced because multiple people could work on the same document at the same time.
Simple content publication	SharePoint or similar easy-to-use and robust tool	For branch or field Web sites, or for the Intranet, software such as SharePoint allows the IT group to develop sophisticated templates that can then be used by less systems savvy users to create effective and attractive Web pages.
Work-flow-driven content publishing	Documentum	For applications such as ReliefWeb or IRIN that require sophisticated workflow and that are run by people whose primary job is to publish, a technology like Documentum offers the power and flexibility required.

Figure 5: OCHA's Architectural Needs and Potential Solutions

4.5.2 Improve OCHA's application development process

Both OCHA's users and its application developers are frustrated by OCHA's application development process.

- Business users feel that they are being delivered applications and platforms that do not meet their needs and that are sometimes of low quality, and that too often simple specifications cannot be met.
- Developers feel that they are often asked to work on projects without sufficient input from users and without clear ownership of the products they are building.

ITS is addressing these issues by adopting an organization-wide application development methodology that does the following:

- Emphasizes creating a clear contract between the users and developers that delineates what is expected. In such a framework, users, not developers, control the specifications. It is the developers' job to advise the users on the implications of the specifications for both cost and schedule.

³⁸ There are other architectural issues for data management, especially those relating to financial systems, that should also be addressed, but that have not been the focus of the IM Review.

- Insists that every IM/IT product have a single point of contact – a product owner – who has sufficient time to define the business requirements, participate in the development processes, monitor the progress of the project, and provide input to developers as needed. Developers should not be responsible for deciding what users want without their input.

This is exactly the right approach. The effort has improved the process and seems to be producing results. But it has not yet gone far enough. The IM Review Team administered a commonly used test to OCHA's ITS development group that measures the ability of a software development team to deliver software as specified, on time, and on budget. The results of the test gave the team a score that is "typical" for most development groups:

A project with this score will likely experience high stress and shaky team dynamics, and the software will ultimately be delivered with less functionality than desired at greater cost and with a longer schedule³⁹

Obviously, typical is not a happy state of affairs and explains why so many software development efforts in both the private and public sectors try the patience of everyone involved. That said, OCHA is well on its way to improving its development practices. With a concerted effort, it should be able to achieve a higher level of proficiency that is described here:

Projects that are virtually guaranteed to succeed in all respects, meeting schedule, budget, quality, and other targets.

Here are some key issues that need to be addressed for this to happen:

- **The current application development methodology is not always practiced, even for major projects.** For instance, the Intranet did not use the rigor of the methodology and suffered because of it.
- **Specifications, and their documentation, are too loose.** The specification documents we reviewed did not go into enough detail to provide a "contract" between the user and developers. The format used in the document did not clearly structure the specifications to make them easy to code from. OCHA should adopt a specification standard, like "use cases," that makes requirements clear and is also well-known among programmers, thus making outsourcing easier.⁴⁰
- **Risk is not addressed early, or often, in project management.** Currently, ITS does not maintain a risk list for the project. Key risks need to be addressed early during requirements gathering and prototyping to avoid costly issues during development. Keeping a risk list in mind at all times is a key factor in project success.
- **There is no change control board.** Once specifications have been baselined, they should be controlled by a change control board that comprises the business user, the technical architect, testers, and other key project personnel. This ensures that there is an orderly process for introducing new specifications and understanding how they will affect project schedule, cost, and scope.

³⁹ The results are explained in some detail in "Appendix: Project Survival Test Results for ITS's Development Group."

⁴⁰ Use cases come from a widely used methodology called the Rational Unified Process (RUP). Besides use cases, the RUP also promotes predictability via clearly defined roles embedded in clearly defined project phases. It is a methodology ITS should consider adopting.

Software project management is actually a very rich subject that cannot be addressed in sufficient detail in this review. OCHA's ITS group needs to upgrade its software development methodology in a few key ways to finish the good work that they have started.

One other recommendation is in order. There is still a substantial level of distrust between ITS's group and users, which is unnecessary. One solution is to have a neutral party (perhaps the IM Governance Team) administer a satisfaction survey every quarter to users of ITS's development services. While the results may at first be disappointing, this form of communication makes it clear how they can better set and meet expectations so that the interaction is harmonious. The effects of this simple practice can be profound.⁴¹

4.5.3 Reduce IT resource bottlenecks through outsourcing

OCHA has a relatively small group of staff developers. This is as it should be: OCHA's job is humanitarian relief, not software development. Nonetheless, to fulfill its mission, OCHA needs strong systems that automate the collection, vetting, analyzing, sharing, and distribution of information *and* a strong internal team to develop and maintain them.

Currently, business users face delays in implementing information applications that they need – even if they have the funding – because OCHA's small staff of developers does not have the capacity to address all of OCHA's business requests. OCHA's ability to address these needs by using outside developers is hampered because of its lack of a well-defined architecture (which, if there were one, would reduce the number of variables outside consultants would need to address), its use of nonstandard software, and its lack of a well-adhered-to industry-standard application development methodology, which would make it easier to plug outside consultants into a well-defined process.

The IM Review Team has already recommended that OCHA upgrade its architecture and improve its application development methodology. We also make this recommendation:

- OCHA's IT developer roles should be redefined so that they emphasize tech-savvy business analysis and project management. Developers should be trained to uphold OCHA's technical and process standards so that OCHA can use outside developers when necessary to address surges in demand.

If the demand for application development services could be met internally, OCHA's team could do it in-house. When there was a surge of demand, then OCHA's developers could then be used to supervise outside capacity. This practice would provide OCHA a great deal more flexibility in meeting business needs, and would not burden it with too much IT developer capacity.

This redefined IT team would form the core of OCHA's IT competence, with a focus on delivering business value through technology. It would be the promoter and guardian of OCHA's

⁴¹ One of the authors of the review helped to run an organization with over 400 developers in the private sector. The organization hired an outside firm to perform an extensive survey with each client on a quarterly basis. At first, the results were quite harsh – we were clearly doing a bad job of setting and meeting client expectations. But the learning curve was rapid: within two quarters our client satisfaction scores rose sharply.

IT architecture and its standards for applications development. It would be, in short, OCHA's technical organizational memory.

4.5.4 Make the field the progenitor of field applications and FIS their steward

Currently, application development for the field is too top-down. Field IMOs are actually quite entrepreneurial and innovative. But they often toil in the forth quadrant of the innovation model. (See Figure 4: OCHA IM Portfolio Attention Map.) It should be FIS's job to help take the best from the field and move it to the first quadrant – to make best practice common practice.

FIS should strengthen its efforts to convoke IMOs and *actively* solicit ideas.

Besides being the generator of most good ideas, the field should also be involved in the design phase of all IM products to be delivered to the field. Too often, active field participation waits for the testing phase, when it is too late to make substantive changes without heavy cost and time penalties.

4.5.5 Have ITS help measure the value of IT investments

Who uses the Intranet, how often, and for what? The field Web sites? OCHA Online?

There is a paucity of information about who is benefiting from OCHA's IT investments. Partly, this is because ITS is generally a non-cost service, which means that its use does not have to be carefully justified. (This is a state of affairs that should probably be rethought – free services are generally not well utilized; perhaps a charge back system should be developed.) This paucity of information is also a result of the lack of standard tools and practices for measuring the usage and effectiveness of IT investments.

ITS should develop a standard set of tools and practices to help the owners of IT products measure their effectiveness. ITS could also provide them guidance on how to improve the value of these products to their target audiences. Too many IT products lack this feedback loop.

4.6 Improve OCHA's IM Capabilities

There are critical capabilities that OCHA leadership and staff must develop to take the IM Review recommendations forward. In most cases, OCHA already has these skills, but they are not deployed everywhere that they need to be.

We can divide these capabilities into two categories:

1. The ability to collect, vet, share, analyze, and disseminate information
2. The ability to manage IM processes and products

4.6.1 The ability to collect, vet, share, analyze, and disseminate information

In order to become the information hub and intellectual leader for the humanitarian community, OCHA must execute information tasks with great skill and efficiency. Currently, OCHA staff receive little or no training on how to do these tasks. Some of the capabilities required include:

- **Information resource/network development and management.** Information collection and vetting need to be done systematically. OCHA offices need to build relationships within their given sphere of responsibility – field, country, regional, or inter-agency context – and to establish and document an information sharing protocol. External (and often even internal) information sources will not provide information unless they benefit. A clear quid pro quo needs to be established. And once information is gathered, OCHA staff need fundamental critical thinking skills to vet that information so that OCHA can be assured that it is credible and fit for decision-making.
- **Information analysis skills.** This is the capability to assess the value of information, its relationship to other like sources, and to define and implement a methodology appropriate for the required decision-maker. It includes the capability to compare methodologies and, as required, analyze findings across multiple methodologies in order to inform decision-making. This capability is largely lacking at OCHA today.

Happily, the skills already exist in parts of OCHA. For instance, both the Ethiopia and oPt offices have excellent information gathering and analysis capabilities. IRIN is another positive example.

In fact, at least both the Ethiopia office (especially as embodied in its Information and Advocacy section) and IRIN share a discipline that may serve as an excellent model for this type of skill: journalism. A good journalist has many of the characteristics that OCHA is looking for:

- Knows how to network to find the best sources of information
- Has a nose for the story – both where to find it and how to vet the information received
- Knows how to protect sources (important in countries with sensitive political issues)
- Often writes about topics more convincingly than discipline experts (e.g., health care professionals) and can synthesize and analyze information across disciplines (very important in the reform environment where OCHA is supposed to do cross-cluster analysis)

For instance, the Ethiopia office has established a wide net of information sources who see great value in collaboration. If UNICEF wants to know what WHO is doing, they go through the OCHA office because they know it will follow through and know exactly whom to ask. When a donor group's jeep was ambushed, they called the Ethiopia office first, because they knew that it would find the right people to contact and would spare no effort to do so. These are very willing sources for OCHA.

The Ethiopia office also knows how to do analysis. When the Ethiopian government refused to declare a cholera epidemic – even when donors were clamoring for them to do so in order to release specially earmarked funds – the Ethiopia office investigated and found out why the government was reluctant.⁴²

⁴² It turns out the government was afraid that there would be a trade ban placed on the country – something that had happened to them in the 1990's.

These skills are not esoteric: everyone at OCHA needs to understand them for OCHA to realize its IM vision. And they should not be difficult to teach. People often learn most quickly from stories. OCHA is rife with such stories that could be made into cases and taught by the best “journalistic” practitioners in OCHA. It would be an excellent way to acknowledge the best work currently being done in the field and at HQ, OCHA staff would find it interesting, and the organization would benefit immensely.

Sometimes information needs go beyond the journalistic discipline, as when large amounts of data need to be analyzed and trends and relationships found. This type of work requires statistical analysis. The IM Review Team has not encountered this skill in OCHA, which is not to say that it does not exist somewhere, but it is probably not as prevalent as it should be. Organizations such as FSAU do have this skill set and could serve as a model to OCHA. If OCHA decides to take on a central repository of indicators, these skills will become especially important.

These skills are more esoteric than journalistic skills. Individual offices probably cannot afford to have resident statistics experts. Yet, there may be an opportunity to leverage statistical skills from regional offices, where such resources could be shared across countries.

4.6.2 The ability to manage IM processes and products

OCHA needs to improve its ability to create, manage, assess and upgrade IM products and services. Without these skills, no matter how well IM product portfolio and IM services are governed, OCHA won’t be able to effectively execute the governance mandates.

The skills to manage IM products and services include:

- **IM services management.** A person responsible for an IM service needs to have deep expertise and an associated professional network relevant to the subject matter (e.g. Search) and in the context of the humanitarian community.. Today, no one at OCHA has this responsibility or skill set. Service owners need to be trained (and provided terms of reference) for establishing business requirements at the enterprise level, designing a system to meet those requirements, delivering the service, and monitoring and updating it. They also need to constantly update their subject matter expertise to keep it state-of-the-art.
- **Portfolio coordinators.** Portfolio managers need to be able to define user requirements across the portfolio (in terms of both IM products and services), manage stakeholder relationships, lead across organizational boundaries, assess product impact in the context of portfolio priorities, and to report on impact to senior stakeholders.
- **Product management.** Product managers know how to define user requirements in terms that can be translated to and executed by a project plan. It also requires assessing the impact of product for the target users within the priorities set by the portfolio manager. This exists at the target user but not portfolio level today such as ReliefWeb, the CAP Section’s work on CA’s, FA’s and CHAP.
- **Prioritization and resource allocation.** Portfolio coordinators need the capability to establish criteria for prioritizing IM investments across their portfolios, to set priorities, to

measure and evaluate resources against priorities and to be held accountable for this. The planning process at OCHA ostensibly does this but in actuality there is no apparent IM product prioritization and resource allocation review, no reviews of product success against criteria, and no one is held accountable.

5 Decisions Points and Implementation Roadmap

As this report has asserted throughout, governance is a, if not the, critical success factor for effective IM management. This section asks the SMT to make clear decisions in order to initiate IM governance that will create organization-wide accountability for achieving this report's recommendations. It then provides a high-level roadmap for implementation.

5.1 Decision Points

To support the recommendations of this report, the SMT needs to establish the governance structure that determines the guiding principles for IM decision making, who makes decisions, and how the results of those decisions will be monitored and evaluated.

The following decisions will initiate the implementation process:

No.	Yes/ No	Decision Title	Decision Description
1		Vision	OCHA's IM vision is: "OCHA will be an intellectual leader and knowledge broker for the humanitarian community"
2		IM Guidelines	No IM product should be built, and some should be retrofitted, to be in accord with the following guidelines: 1. Every IM product is part of a managed portfolio. 2. Each information category (domain) has a designated owner. 3. Unconnected information islands should be avoided. 4. When practical, the unit of analysis should be information, not documents. 5. Information – normalized and with clear provenance – is collected only once and re-used as necessary. 6. IM is seamlessly embedded into OCHA's practices. 7. Information can be easily manipulated and viewed in ways that make sense to OCHA's stakeholders.
3		SMT's role in governance	SMT sets the vision and guidelines for IM and it determines overall IT investment.
4		IM Governance Team	The IM Governance Team will be responsible for coordinating and assessing the implementation of the IM Review's five recommendations: 1. Create an organization-wide cross-cluster knowledgebase for key humanitarian information and analysis 2. Revise the way IM is governed 3. Systematize the way innovation is spread and standards are set 4. Improve OCHA's IM capabilities 5. Enhance OCHA's capacity to use technology to support its IM needs The IM Governance team has decision rights for: • IT architectural plans • IT infrastructure strategy • IM product catalogues • IM service product priorities

			The IM Governance Team will have 8 members: ● Chairperson ● Overall Portfolio Coordinator ● The five Portfolio Coordinators (Advocacy, Coordination, Funding, Internal Communications, and Policy) ● The IM Services Coordinator Specific roles that make up the IM Governance Team are: ● IM Governance Team Chair: The IM Chairperson is either the deputy USG, or the Chief of Staff, who has responsibility to: ○ Work with the Overall IM Portfolio Coordinator to create consensus ○ Be the final decision maker, as necessary ○ Report to the USG on IM progress ○ Overall Portfolio Coordinator: Functions include: ○ Primary staff resource to the IM Governance Team ○ Ensuring that the product portfolios and IM services are optimized to IM strategy and vision ○ Reducing bureaucratic logjams ○ Change management ▪ Reinforcing positive deviants ▪ Bringing closure to IM issues ▪ Coordinating IM training ▪ Promoting innovation and standards stewardship across all IM products & services ○ Measuring and reporting progress to the chairperson ○ Collating and explaining the overall OCHA IM budget ● IM Portfolio Coordinators. There will be a Coordinator for each product portfolio: advocacy, coordination, funding, internal communications, and policy. Each coordinator will be accountable for ensuring that the portfolio is cohesive, innovative, efficient and effective. ● IM Services Coordinator. This role will ensure that the portfolio is innovative, efficient and effective and that non-innovative services are outsourced or ceased. ● IM Innovation & Standards Steward. This role will oversee the development of all IM standards and mentor those who set and adhere to them ● IM Training Coordinator. This role will develop the capacity building program aimed at senior management, the Governance Team and field staff.
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To be developed:

5		OCHA Knowledgebase	OCHA should pursue creating an organization-wide knowledge base of indicators, synthesis, and analysis to underpin its desire to become an intellectual leader and knowledge broker for the humanitarian community.
6		IT Architecture	OCHA should undertake a concerted effort to upgrade its IT architecture to support its vision and IM guidelines. This investment may be substantial, and will need to be justified by sound business reasoning.
7		IM Services	AIMB will establish a set of IM services meant to support all of OCHA's products and services. Sample services include: • Search • Content and taxonomy management • Information domain management • Application services (development, usability, security, maintenance) • Technical architecture • Monitoring and evaluation (user research, analytics, evaluations, metrics) • IM innovation and standards • Oversight (budget, product, project)

5.2 Implementation Roadmap (October 2007-end 2008)

The following timeline represents the critical outputs for year one of the IM Governance Team. For each major output, the lead, benefit, expected completion date (assuming work starts in October), dependencies and OCHA Strategic Objective are indicated. Although full implementation of the IM Review recommendations is expected to take longer than a year, this is what we expect to accomplish by the end of 2008.

Ref	Critical Outputs	Due Date	Task Lead	Benefits	Dependencies/ Constraints	OCHA Strategic Objectives
1.1	TOR established for IM Governance Team and its members	October 2007	Overall Portfolio Coordinator	Governance team members are clear on their roles; expectation setting	Overall Portfolio Coordinator post filled	Objective 3.1 – Improved management practices for one OCHA
1.2	IM Governance Team established/roles assigned	October 2007	Overall Portfolio Coordinator	Clear accountability		Objective 3.1
1.3	First IM Governance Team meeting; decision on frequency of meetings	November 2007	Overall Portfolio Coordinator	Visible recognition that process is underway	Chair, Portfolio Coordinators and IM Services Coordinator in place	Objective 3.1
1.4	IM Governance Team training	November 2007	Training focal point	Governance team is clear on how to do its work	Training focal point in place	Objective 3.1
1.5	Communication and education plan for OCHA on IM vision, guidelines and implementation plan	December 2007	Overall Portfolio Coordinator	OCHA staff understand their role and are willing to support the outcome		Objective 3.1
1.6	New product/website protocol established	December 2007	Overall Portfolio Coordinator/ Portfolio Coordinators	All new products and websites conform with overall portfolio		Objective 2.5 – Strengthened IM based on common standards and best practices
1.7	ICT Review completed by Gartner	December 2007	IM Service Coordinator	Clear recommendations on changes to OCHA's architecture	Review TOR agreed and process	Objective 2.5

					completed on time	
1.8	TOR for individual product and service owners established and training completed	January 2008	Overall Portfolio Coordinator/ Training focal point	Individuals are clear on their roles and how to carry them out		Objective 3.1
1.9	Version 1.0 of new architecture design	January 2008	IM Services Coordinator	Able to predict benefits to products and services	ICT Review by Gartner is completed	Objective 2.5
2.0	Information products organized by function and rationalized with stakeholder requirements	February 2008	Portfolio Coordinators	First step towards OCHA Product Catalog	Training completed	Objective 2.5
2.1	A service model in place for each of the critical IM services	February 2008	IM Services Coordinators	Effective and efficient IM	Service owners established	Objective 2.5
2.2	Application development methodology training completed	March 2008	IM Services Coordinator/ Training focal point	Industry standard development methodology; applications aligned better with user needs	Training not prioritized by ITS	Objective 2.5
2.3	Signed critical outsourcing contract	March 2008	IM Services Coordinator	Surge capacity for ITS	New architecture defined	Objective 2.5
2.4	Version 1.0 of OCHA Product Catalog and IM Attention Map	March 2008	Overall Portfolio Coordinator/ IM Services Coordinator	Stocktaking of all OCHA products; ability to evaluate complete portfolio	Portfolio Coordinators have finalized product list by function	Objective 2.5
2.5	IM Services capabilities review	April 2008	IM Services Coordinator	Ability to assess how well products can be supported	Service owners functioning	Objective 2.5
2.6	Assessment of OCHA's analytical skills completed	April 2008	Overall Portfolio Coordinator	Stocktaking of OCHA's capacity to undertake analysis		Objective 2.1 – Action-oriented analysis of humanitarian trends and emerging policy issues

2.7	Scope and vision of OCHA Knowledgebase and analytical framework established	April 2008	IM Governance Team	Ability to begin project designing	Staff time; input from cluster lead agencies	Objective 2.1
2.8	Evaluation of OCHA Product Catalog completed and adjustments recommended	May 2008	Overall Portfolio Coordinator	Stakeholder information needs are met		Objective 2.5
2.9	Version 1.0 of humanitarian indicators	May 2008	Standards focal point	A common set of indicators upon which to base products and services	ECHO funded unit in Geneva is fully functional; input of partners and donors	Objective 2.3 – A common approach to needs assessments and impact evaluation
23.0	6 month review of IM Governance Team and adjustments recommended	June 2008	Overall Portfolio Coordinator	Improvements to structure and function		Objective 3.1
3.1	Review progress to date of ICT architecture and implications for products and services	June 2008	IM Governance Team Chair	Able to predict benefits to products and services	ICT Review recommendations resourced by SMT	Objective 2.5
3.2	Domain mapping completed	July 2008	IM Services Coordinator	Rationalized information systems		Objective 2.5
3.3	Standards and practices documented with clear roles and responsibilities	July 2008	Standards focal point	Efficient, predictable and decentralized IM	Standards stewardship training completed	Objective 2.5
3.4	Prioritized IM products and services Attention Map to feed into work planning processes	August 2008	Overall Portfolio Coordinator	Ability to influence work planning and resource allocation for 2009		Objective 2.5
3.5	First analytical skills training held	September 2008	Training focal point	Build OCHA's capacity to undertake analysis	Case studies in place for training model	Objective 2.1
3.6	Standards trained service and product owners at field level	October 2008	Training/ Standards focal point	Build OCHA's capacity to standardize its IM products and services		Objective 2.5

3.7	Design of OCHA Knowledgebase completed and presented to USG	December 2008	IM Governance Team	Visible IM and humanitarian leadership	Engagement by field, HQ, partners, donors	Objective 2.1
3.8	One year Review of IM Governance Team	December 2008	Overall Portfolio Coordinator	Improvements to structure and function		Objective 3.1

6 Appendix: Product Evaluation for the Consolidated Appeals Process

The Consolidated Appeals Process was established 15 years ago under General Assembly Resolution 46/182. An external review of the CAP was produced in 2007.⁴³ The current review is focused on the CAP in the context of the OCHA IM Review and is not intended to be an in-depth assessment of the CAP itself. The external CAP review focused on the various information products created by the CAP, and not on the process itself. The products included in the review are the Consolidated Appeal, the MYR Review, the Flash Appeal, and the FTS (Financial Tracking System). It is recognized that the CHAP is the foundation for developing a Consolidated Appeal or a Flash Appeal. However, the CHAP did not form part of our review.

As stated in the 2007 CAP Technical Guide, the CAP is a process triggered by a major or complex emergency, *determined to be such by the IASC*, in which “the UN Humanitarian Coordinator of the affected country initiates with the member organisations and standing invitees of the IASC (hereafter referred to as the IASC Country Team), and other relevant non-IASC organisations an *inclusive, coordinated programme cycle* of:

- strategic planning (leading to a Common Humanitarian Action Plan, or CHAP);
- resource mobilisation (which, together with the CHAP, makes the Consolidated Appeal or Flash Appeal);
- coordinated implementation;
- joint monitoring and evaluation;
- revision of the CHAP if necessary; and
- reporting on results.”⁴⁴

6.1 Product Accord with IM Guidelines

As currently practiced, the CAP generally conforms well to OCHA’s IM guidelines. Nonetheless, there are areas where crucial improvements would make it considerably more effective.

1. **Every IM product is part of a managed portfolio.** The CAP Section of OCHA sits within the newly established branch focused on donor and partner relationships. This new development provides an opportunity to establish a portfolio approach to meet donor and partner information requirements in support of the Humanitarian agenda.
2. **Each information category (domain) has a designated owner.** The CAP Section, as a steward for the IASC, focuses on ensuring that all information produced during the process is verifiable and, if the information cannot be verified, that an explanation can be provided.⁴⁵ While the CAP Section does manage the financial information in FTS it does not manage country based information, emergency-based information nor any form of indicators related to humanitarian responses. These are locally managed and one category of information (e.g.

⁴³ Porter, Toby. An External Review of the CAP. 18 April 2002.

⁴⁴ OCHA CAP Section. How to prepare a ten-page CAP Mid-Year Review. April 2007.

⁴⁵ See Somalia 2007 CAP and instructions dated April 2007 “How to prepare a ten-page CAP Mid-Year Review.”

country demographics) can be dispersed among several humanitarian agencies. This is being addressed to some degree by the clusters.

3. **Unconnected information ponds should be avoided.** FTS is the sole source of connecting up information in the CAP, other than the Consolidated Appeals, Flash Appeals, and CHAP documents. Those submitted appeals for funding tend to work independently from others – thus reinforcing information ponds.
4. **When practical, the unit of analysis should be information, not documents.** This is not possible today given that neither the information architecture nor the technical architecture will permit it. Content is not tagged or stored in discrete, addressable units. A very simple example is that many of the CAP documents are circulated in email in read-only PDF format, which means individuals must read the entire document to locate the information they are seeking.
5. **Information – normalized and with clear provenance – is collected only once and re-used as necessary.** The CAP Section has done a substantial amount of work to ensure the information products are normalized and that information is cited and re-used as necessary. The Common Approach to Needs Assessment and Analysis stresses the need for improvement in the normalization of indicators, definitions, and denominators in order to improve the quality of the CAP. Work to date has clarified responsibilities in terms of the country team's accountability for the information it collects and the reporting agencies' and donors' responsibility for the data they report on funding.

According to Marcel Vaessen⁴⁶, acting manager of FTS, the information it stores is centrally managed via FTS and easily reused as necessary by the field office, updated by donor field offices, and extracted and manipulated. The Cap Section vets the data to ensure their accuracy. Data are extracted and used in various information products including the CHAP, the CA, and the Flash Appeal and reported on the ReliefWeb site.

There are, however, further opportunities for improvement in normalization:

- FTS seeks to be the primary and real-time source for all funded humanitarian projects, as well as unfunded projects. According to the CAP Section head,⁴⁷ this goal has not yet been achieved, a fact confirmed by the field mission.⁴⁸ The quality of the information sources used in CAP-related reports varies.⁴⁹ For example, under the section in the 2007 Technical Guidelines for Consolidated Appeals on criteria for prioritization of projects submitted in 2007, the sample criteria cover critical areas such as sectoral, organizational, demographic, and temporal, but the process does not provide any assistance in establishing indicators (or even referring to baseline indicators), nor does it refer to information sources that set a specific norm.⁵⁰

⁴⁶ In-person interview June 19, 2007.

⁴⁷ In-person interview June 20, 2007

⁴⁸ Trip to Eastern Africa, August 2007.

⁴⁹ In-person interview with CAP Section head, June 20, 2007.

⁵⁰ Technical Guidelines for the Consolidated Appeals 2007pg.7 Criteria for Prioritisation of Projects.

6. **IM is seamlessly embedded into OCHA's practices.** IM is not embedded seamlessly in the CAP practice. Specifically, supporting financial and country data are not available in an easy-to-use form within an online reporting template, and CAP proposals are available as word or PDF documents that must be consulted online vs. within the day-to-day activities of the field or HQ staff.

The need for seamless embedding becomes more critical as the information is used (or more specifically, has the potential to be used) in monitoring progress against objectives and provides the basis upon which donors can assess impact. For example, the FTS forms the basis for analysis by the desk officers who use the one page of appeal funding information to identify how much donors gave in those countries. The CERF relies on the FTS to analyze the underfunded allocations twice a year and to follow up on linkages of CERF and FTS, and CERF and appeals. It would be more effective and efficient if the data were automatically available in the work processes that leverage this information, such as the preparation of SitReps, summaries for Head Office, cluster analyses, and emergency responses.

7. **Information can be easily manipulated and viewed in ways that make sense to OCHA's stakeholders.** The two primary audiences of the CAP are donors in terms of prioritizing needs and contributing funding, and the Humanitarian Coordinator and country teams in terms of assessing, identifying, monitoring, and proposing funding needs. Since we did not specifically interview these stakeholders, it is unclear whether information is organized in ways that make sense to them.

What we do know is that, without a clear articulation of key indicators and the means to track progress against them, the information is not organized in any form that is easily analyzed. Other than financials, which are available in the FTS, it is difficult to compare impact data across countries or across responses. Indicators for monitoring and evaluating progress against a specific set of funding objectives, such as targets for progress against specific goals, do not appear to exist. This fact highlights a significant management hole in terms of evidence-based and results-based management.

We recommend reference to the 2002 External CAP Review⁵¹ as a good starting place for conducting an analysis of stakeholder satisfaction with this specific principle.

We do recommend that the CAP document be electronically based, with a template that makes it possible to slice and dice information and present it in views that are easily compiled from those sections and data sets that are most useful to each stakeholder audience.

6.2 Oversight

The IASC has strategic oversight of the CAP and thus sets the process agenda and standards. The CAP Section of OCHA has overall responsibility for ensuring that the process documents are completed as accurately as possible and are within the timeframe established by the IASC. There are significant opportunities here to improve standards in terms of interoperability among data sets, information gathering methods, and analytical reporting.

⁵¹ Toby Porter. An External Review of the CAP. Commissioned by OCHA's Evaluation and Studies Unit. 18 April 2002.

The IASC CAP Sub-Working Group represents the Humanitarian Community's perspective on the CAP. A meeting held on June 21st 2007 included such topics as issues with the Mid-Year Reviews, Turning CAP into HAP (Humanitarian Appeals Process, i.e., a coordinated, inclusive, strategic humanitarian plan), and project-less CAPs.⁵² It is not clear whether they have any input or role to play with respect to IM.

As part of the Donors and External Relations Branch, the CAP is one of the products and services that OCHA coordinates with partners and donors. The CAP could benefit from oversight by IM Services such as Search, Taxonomy Management, and IT Architecture that review and develop objectives for all partner and donor products and services. The bottom line impact is improved common knowledge of any given humanitarian situation, progress against goals, and the ability to find information immediately when needed. This is not possible today.

6.2.1 Standards

Standards, defined broadly as “a quality bar that is expected to be met,” do exist in the form of process guidelines and data standards for the FTS. Standards related to the collection and use of information in terms of how to do the work (how to analyze, how to recognize an authoritative source, how to collect evidence, how to apply a specific methodology) need to be developed, and individuals need to be trained or hired in with these skill sets. These standards of practice are particularly important given the emphasis on evidence-based decision-making.

IM standards such as metadata standards, information lifecycle management standards (i.e., how to manage information across its useful life), and user presentation standards do exist for specific CAP products such as FTS, and their adoption is encouraged across all CAP products and services, but they do not exist in the context of all donor and partner products and services. Much more could be done to adopt UNIWG standards, to contribute to the development of an OCHA-wide metadata strategy, to ensure consistency of look and feel with the rest of OCHA's products and services, and to develop a group of standard information sets for any given country that are tracked and reported on over time.

Anecdotally,⁵³ standards adoption for financial reporting continues to be problematic in terms of how financial information reported by CAP may vary with financial reporting by the funding organization and by the agency or NGO. There are opportunities for improved technical support of IM as it relates to the CAP:

- Today, other than the FTS, proposals and reports in progress are shared via email. They are then reviewed and edited by the CAP Section team, with versions going back and forth over email until the proposal meets requirements and is ready for review. Technical support in the form of a collaborative authoring environment would be very useful in speeding up the review process and in enabling in-process updates. The Humanitarian Community might consider using a secure collaborative space for reviewing the documents as well, including establishing a content and taxonomy management system that supports different views of information for different needs by the various stakeholder groups.

⁵² IASC CAP Sub-Working Group Meeting Agenda, Thursday, 21 June 2007, Room F-3, Palais des Nations (3:00 p.m.)

⁵³ Interviews held in Geneva June 19-21st, 2007.

- The CAP Section plays a clearinghouse or match-making function (implicitly but de facto) in making it easy to identify and refer projects of interest to funding bodies. There are interesting technology-enabled models already developed for doing this, particularly in the scientific world but even in the nonprofit world, that may be models for how OCHA matches response needs to the various players in the humanitarian community, whether they are NGOs or agencies. These types of services provide increased transparency and current information that may be lacking in the primarily paper-based process that exists today. For example, Innocentive at <http://www.innocentive.com/> and Innocentives work with the Rockefeller Foundation (see http://www.rockfound.org/about_us/news/2007/0720first_seeker.shtml).

6.3 Potential For IM Revolution

The CAP is an important information source for assessing, monitoring, and delivering decision-making insights as they relate to the field. There is a significant opportunity to leverage knowledge that is exchanged among the field, donors, partners, OCHA, and other humanitarian players. Being able to achieve this exchange in real-time or at least in some meaningful way as events unfold will require capacity building in the field, in OCHA IM Services, and in relationship building with the agencies and NGOs. Time could be better spent analyzing the data and putting it to use rather than gathering it. Several examples serve to illustrate the point: The CAP Section spent 7 weeks this year coordinating data compilation for the Mid-Year Review; the PIO for Uganda would like to see weekly financial updates yet the FTS is considered to be almost never up-to-date; back in Geneva, Robert Smith would like to conduct trends analysis to identify critical funding gaps. This is not possible today. Most importantly, priorities will need to be set in order to ensure that the effort invested is having the greatest possible impact. Today, the flow of information is slow and linear in an environment that is incredibly dynamic, complex, and volatile.

As the Coordinator, OCHA plays a critical role in matching needs and available resources. This is a significant piece of the donor/partner portfolio of responsibilities. Currently, the matching effort is manual, informed largely by a paper-based process and a database reflecting financial commitments. Technology can increase the availability of information in a timely manner, matching known needs to known funding sources on the basis of predetermined criteria. A notification system can be set up to communicate opportunities for funding to interested parties as they occur. Such a system could be extremely beneficial in the case of Flash Appeals.

The CAP and the CAP Section have a critical role to play in the Humanitarian Reform, as they have a global perspective on a local (country) disaster or emergency, as well as the sum of all reported humanitarian aid. Their knowledge is important to leverage in the development of IM standards. With OCHA as steward, these two bodies can inform the work of establishing and managing standards on which analyses, particularly the impact of investments, are based. This work will be essential for ongoing commitment by funding agencies.

6.4 Specific Tasks For The IM Revolution

- Use training, new hiring opportunities, and technology to develop the capacity to engage the field and the broader humanitarian community in targeted collective intelligence

- efforts. Make information gathering, assessment, and decision-making iterative and timely vs. linear and delayed.
- Develop the capacity and the motivation to collect insights and developments as they occur so that the review process focuses mostly on the known state and projected state and required action, rather than on data gathering.
 - Engage a content management system (people, process, technology) that makes it possible to prepopulate CAP documents with content collected and reported throughout the process and that, just as importantly, can be easily mapped to other content producers who can contribute to and use it but may choose to store their content elsewhere.
 - Provide each country team with the capability to analyze country data, draw conclusions, and report findings.
 - Create an electronic version of all CAP products and services and stop paper production. Use content templates to make it possible to produce, monitor, and assess investment on a more timely basis.
 - Increase the capacity to monitor progress against indicators in a real-time manner for immediate needs and to learn lessons from very specific kinds of disasters and emergencies in various stages to improve the humanitarian response. Consider the work around “wisdom of crowds”⁵⁴ and prediction analytics as potential models for assessing humanitarian aid options.

⁵⁴ <http://www.amazon.com/Wisdom-Crowds-James-Surowiecki/dp/0385721706>

7 Appendix: Product Evaluation for HICs

OCHA Online describes HICs this way:

HICs aim to ensure that individuals and organizations involved in humanitarian operations have access to the benefits of information management tools to assess, plan, implement, and monitor humanitarian assistance. HICs are an inter-organizational resource whose products and services are available to the entire humanitarian community. HICs provide surge capacity to the humanitarian community, and particularly to the co-ordination function, usually (but not exclusively) in the context of complex emergencies.

HICs can also be described as a humanitarian community Rorschach test. Mention HICs, and people have radically different reactions to what they see:

- Many see an indispensable tool, the best that OCHA has to offer in terms of service, data, and analysis. Keith McKenzie, the acting HC for Uganda, has a typical reaction for this cohort. He described the HIC for Darfur as “incredibly good. They reached out to people to solicit and provide information. They did excellent work providing maps and data sets for population, the water sector, and mortality. We would dearly love to have a HIC in Uganda.”⁵⁵
- Others see a waste of time and money. One HC described the Afghanistan HIC this way: “The HIC was useless. They solicited information from us and it took two months before we saw any output. And there was never any really useful analysis. HICs are for donors and not for action.”
- Still others see HICs as funding magnets. While it is often difficult to fund an IMU – because they are often viewed by the donor community as overhead – HICs are more attractive funding targets because they can be classified as emergency aid. IMUs often cannot afford the full range of products and services offered by a HIC.
- Finally, HICs are viewed as bulwarks against some OCHA heads of office who are seen as sometimes being reluctant to share their IMU resources with the rest of the humanitarian community. Because HICs are supposed to be a shared service, they are designed to be largely independent of HoO control.⁵⁶

The diversity of opinion about HICs is a product of what is best about HICs and what is their most frustrating characteristic: their celebration of improvisation. HICs have in general been eager to adapt to the situation on the ground and to do their best to please those working in the humanitarian community. The downside to this approach is that they are not predictable; people in the humanitarian community do not know what to expect or how to measure a HIC’s value.⁵⁷

A number of reviews of the HICs have already been done, including ones for Afghanistan, Liberia, Iraq, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, and Banda Aceh.⁵⁸ This appendix will not rehash this work. Instead, it will look at the HICs through the lens of the IM Review framework.

⁵⁵ This high opinion of the HICs was also shared by people in FSAU and USAID.

⁵⁶ This opinion is held by desk officers in CRD as well as HCs and donors in the field. However, the reality is often different – HoOs do manage to sometimes control HICs.

⁵⁷ For instance, some HICs focus on only operational work while others also do analysis, depending on the HIC manager, OCHA HoO or HC’s preferences and skill sets.

⁵⁸ For instance, “An Evaluation of HICs including Case Studies of HICs for Iraq, Afghanistan, and Liberia,” Lewis Sida and Chris Szpak, August, 2004.

7.1 Product Accord with IM Guidelines

Do HICs always purpose information to provide insight for decision-making? The ambiguity surrounding HICs extends even here. There is no clarity about whether HICs should provide analysis or whether this is the purview of the individual clusters. HIC managers, AIMB staff, and donors and partners differ in their views of whether HICs can, or should, provide analysis.

Who is right? If one accepts the recommendations of the IM Review, then the answer is unambiguous. Part of the HIC mandate must be to provide the analytical skills – journalistic and statistical⁵⁹ – to help decision makers make sense of complex and quickly changing situations. If necessary, HIC staffing and capacity issues that would prevent them from providing analytical work should be addressed.

This section comments on how well the HICs conform with OCHA's IM guidelines:

1. **Every IM product is part of a managed portfolio.** The role of the HIC has been a source of questioning and debate since their inception. There have been papers written and conferences held. This issue has not yet been resolved. Can HICs be created in areas where OCHA already has an office or are they only for emergency surges where OCHA does not have a presence? What is the relationship between a HIC and an IMU?

Given this confusion, it is difficult to say how or where HICs fit into OCHA's overall portfolio of products. OCHA needs to put a stake in the ground and move on.

2. **Each information category (domain) has a designated owner.** Information categories – for instance, lists of sectors and place codes – used in HICs have no designated owner. Each HIC has its own set of these values.
3. **Unconnected information islands should be avoided.** HICs are the ultimate information island. The information they contain typically stays only in the HIC and does not inform any of OCHA's other information sources.
4. **When practical, the unit of analysis should be information, not documents.** HICs generally do not explicitly support making the unit of analysis information and not documents. For instance, there are no formalized databases of fields or indicators. In fact, there are no forms (i.e., all information is collected in documents) other than for contact information in most HICs.
5. **Information – normalized and with clear provenance – is collected only once and re-used as necessary.** Information created by HICs is not normalized. Some HICs have been designed to establish a clear provenance (the Sri Lankan HIC uses a "Data Source" field for weekly update reports, meetings, and situation reports⁶⁰), whereas the others do not (the Lebanon HIC has no indication of provenance in its lists of resources – though often the provenance is indicated within the document itself⁶¹). In general, the same document may be posted in multiple places within a HIC and may be used elsewhere in

⁵⁹ See the section on Capabilities for more on these skills as they apply to OCHA.

⁶⁰ <http://www.humanitarianinfo.org/srilanka/catalogue/Catalogues.aspx?CatID=60>

⁶¹ <http://www.humanitarianinfo.org/lebanon/>

OCHA in several areas (e.g., situation reports.) The exception, once again, was the Sri Lankan HIC, which had a well-defined content management system.

As consumers of information, on the other hand, HICs do conform to using information that is collected only once: some HICs have feeds from FTS, IRIN, and ReliefWeb.⁶²

6. **IM is seamlessly embedded into OCHA's practices.** Because of their one-off nature, there has been very little effort to embed information management practices around the HICs.

That said, it is clear that HICs that are closer to the humanitarian crisis are more effective than those that are housed in capital cities because both the inputs (data and information) and outputs (analysis and maps) are closer to decision makers and operations. In this sense, HICs should be "embedded" into the humanitarian crisis.

7. **Information can be easily manipulated and viewed in ways that make sense to OCHA's stakeholders.** Most HICs do not have extensive content or information management capabilities. They tend to post information in lists. The Sri Lankan HIC does allow for filtering on content by source and sector. In general, information organization in HICs is limited.

7.2 Opportunities and Challenges

The biggest challenge for HICs is existential. Should they exist? And if so, then as what? Unless these questions are answered, then it is difficult to address the opportunities and challenges in oversight, standards, and technology.

The IM Review Team would argue that, functionally, a HIC is no different from a well-resourced IMU. Some would say that it is important to maintain the distinction between IMUs, which are OCHA-funded entities, and HICs, which are shared services. This, at least to our understanding, is a distinction without a difference. What other function does OCHA have than to serve the humanitarian community? Both IMUs and HICs should be purposed to support the clusters.

In our view, IMUs like HICs should feed information into the rest of OCHA that can be used for further analysis and decision making. (As we have already noted, HICs are the quintessential information island.) Both IMUs and HICs are close to the ground where humanitarian action takes place and thus should be invaluable information sources. As such, they should be structured and purposed to feed into OCHA's proposed knowledgebase.

So, when to use a HIC as opposed to an IMU? It would seem that HICs are useful in three situations:

1. When there is no existing IMU to support a humanitarian crisis, or the IMU does not have sufficient capacity.
2. When an IMU is insufficiently funded and there is a strong humanitarian case, the HIC concept can be used as a funding mechanism.

⁶² Based on a series of interviews with Patrick Gordon, May, 2007.

3. When the humanitarian crisis is geographically distant from the IMU. For instance, there may be an IMU in Kampala, but the crisis is in the northern part of the country several days away.

HICs have an important role to play to support cross-cluster coordination. But originally conceptualized as distinct from the rest of OCHA's information management practices, they need to be integrated into OCHA's emerging IM framework.

7.2.1 Oversight

HICs clearly primarily serve partners and the field. FIS currently is the HIC steward. Nonetheless, one of the product portfolios – probably coordination – should be made responsible for the HIC's success.

7.2.2 Standards

The current HIC “bespoke” model is confusing for users and unnecessarily slow and expensive to deploy. The entire user experience, data model, and technical architecture should be standardized across all HICs.

Unless there are strong arguments to do differently, *these standards should be the same as those adopted for field Web sites*. The requirements of a HIC are not sufficiently different from those of an IMU to justify two distinct development paths. HICs should be an integral part of OCHA's IM product portfolio for the field, not a customized exotic.

7.2.3 Technology

Given that HICs are quite different across various implementations, it is hard to speak of technical issues much beyond the need for standardization. Obviously, HICs need to be designed in order to support operations in the deep field. HIC technology should work seamlessly with other OCHA IM systems.

7.3 Potential For IM Revolution

The potential for IM Revolution for HICs lies within OCHA's ability to standardize them in order to:

- Create predictability for users
- Provide a seamless transition from a HIC to an IMU (or to a development or government partner)
- Plug the information and analysis created within the HICs into OCHA's knowledgebase.

7.4 Specific Tasks For The IM Revolution

- Clarify the TOR for HICs, including their requirements to provide analysis and their relationship to IMUs.
- Have HICs use the same data categories (e.g., for p-codes, sectors) as used throughout the rest of OCHA.

- Ensure that the information kept in HICs is normalized and have it flow to OCHA's knowledgebase.
- Ensure that a business portfolio (probably coordination) has oversight of HICs from a business perspective. FIS should be the steward of the product.
- Make the HICs a standard product from usability, functionality, and architecture perspectives. All these attributes should be as similar as possible to those used in field sites to ensure consistency and to reduce costs.

8 Appendix: Product Evaluation for Policy and Guidance

The Policy and Guidance Management System (PGMS) is currently being implemented and is scheduled to be fully developed and rolled out to OCHA staff in phases over the coming year. Its purpose is to provide a single place for OCHA staff to find corporate policies, procedures, and SOPs that are approved or under development. Currently, as there is no central site for OCHA-wide corporate guidance, too many staff members are unaware of the guidance which is available, it is not centrally approved, and staff would have difficulty finding it even if they knew that it existed.⁶³

PGMS will save time in many situations. Once the system is accessible and fully functioning OCHA employees will be able to easily access the relevant policies and procedures for such activities as creating a background paper for SMT on protection in a country, setting up a field group for local access issues, or opening an office.

The system will also address the numerous gaps in guidance for key operational processes and procedures which hinders OCHA's ability to provide high quality, consistent response in emergency and non-emergency situations.

8.1 Product Accord with IM Guidelines

As currently conceived, PGMS generally conforms well to OCHA's IM guidelines. Nonetheless, there are areas where crucial improvements would make it considerably more effective. The product does purpose information to provide insight for decision-making. Well written guidance will help OCHA staff make operational decisions even under the stress of emergency situations. Given the relatively high turnover rate among OCHA staff, easy access to such guidance is essential for quality, consistency, efficiency, and safety.

1. **Every IM product is part of a managed portfolio.** PGMS is blessed with a business owner that is actively – if not to say passionately – involved in its success. However, there is yet to be identified the IM product portfolio owners for the field and HQ.
2. **Each information category (domain) has a designated owner.** The PGMS will need to rely on a standard list of regions and countries in order to classify some of the policies. Currently, no one has oversight responsibility for the region/country information category (domain). The IM Review has identified at least six different country databases in OCHA, with several more being requested. This redundancy and lack of synchronization should be eliminated.
3. **Unconnected information islands should be avoided.** This principle generally does not apply to internally focused IM products.
4. **When practical, the unit of analysis should be information, not documents.** As currently conceived, the PGMS has as its unit of analysis the document. We recommend that individual sections of policies be referenceable so that they can be used as needed in Web applications, forms, and other places to aid embedding. (See the section on

⁶³ Much of this section is based upon conversations with Hansjoerg Strohmeyer and Anne Cubilie from PDSB.

principle “3: IM is seamlessly embedded in OCHA’s practices,” for more background on how this type of embedding should be enabled by the PGMS.)

5. **Information – normalized and with clear provenance – is collected only once and re-used as necessary.** PGMS information will be stored once and its owner/creator will be clearly indicated. A feedback mechanism will allow users to easily comment on material and recommend improvements.
6. **IM is seamlessly embedded into OCHA’s practices.** As currently conceived, PGMS information will *not* be embedded into OCHA’s practices. This, we believe, will undermine PGMS’s ability to fully achieve its potential in promoting effectiveness and efficiency. To use the information, users will be forced to find the appropriate document and then, within the document (which may be lengthy) the appropriate section. In some instances, this may make sense (e.g., in the case of cross-cutting policy instructions where the full context of the corporate position should be read and understood – such as OCHA’s role in supporting protection).

More often, however, embedding the policy into the flow of what staff are doing will provide OCHA the benefits of guidance without requiring employees to consciously search or access the PGMS. For instance, there may be detailed guidance on how to count Internally Displaced People (IDPs) for situation reports. If the situation report became an electronic form, this guidance could be placed next to the IDP entry field as a help button. In this way, the guidance would be immediately available to the staff member using the form without that staff member ever having to do a search for it.

Embedding can go even further to create more efficiency and greater compliance. If, for instance, a policy stated that all situation reports should provide the source for the number of IDPs affected by an emergency, and if a form was used to collect this information, then the form could enforce this policy without the staff member ever having to read it by providing a drop down list of sources (e.g., the ICRC) and forcing the user to choose from the list before the form was saved.

PGMS should have the support of senior management and OCHA’s IT section to develop these functionalities, and its project charter should include being on the lookout for taking advantage of these types of embedded opportunities wherever they may exist.

7. **Information can be easily manipulated and viewed in ways that make sense to OCHA’s stakeholders.** As specified by PDSB, the PGMS will be compliant with this principle. Policies will be organized primarily by “guidance number” – a method used by similar organizations such as UNDP and the World Bank. This will allow users to browse related policies much as one can do in a library that uses the Dewey decimal system. Policies will also be able to be created and searched for at the global, regional, and country levels.

8.2 Opportunities and Challenges

To realize its potential, the PGMS faces several challenges that should be addressed in the context of the IM review.

8.2.1 Oversight

From a product standpoint, the PGMS should be seen as part of the greater portfolio of IM products dedicated to HQ and the field. For instance, other IM products for these audiences could benefit from embedding policies into their applications and forms. Currently there is no one responsible for this overall view.

The PGMS will need to rely on a standard list of regions and countries in order to classify some of the policies. Currently, no one has oversight responsibility for the region/country information category (domain). The IM Review has identified at least six different country databases in OCHA, with several more being requested. This redundancy and lack of synchronization should be eliminated.

The IM Review has suggested that a key IM Service is information domain management. A role should be created to map the information domains that OCHA requires (e.g., country, donor, partner, emergency, etc.) and to insure that someone fills the role of being responsible for the attributes and data stored in these domains.

8.2.2 Standards

On the positive side of the ledger, the PGMS is a meta-standards setter. It has created standards for how policy documents are to be created and represented. It also correctly sees itself as the steward of policies, but not as their owners. As steward, PDSB will require that every policy have an owner who is responsible for its content.

On the negative side, the PGMS will be using OCHA's intranet as its platform. The intranet's effectiveness is undermined by the fact that its information architecture and functionality do not conform to basic Web standards.⁶⁴ Because of this, users will have a hard time using and navigating the site. Also problematic, the intranet's poor use of page real estate provides too little room for the applications it supports, reducing their ease-of-use.

For the PGMS to be effective, its platform, the OCHA intranet, will need to be substantially enhanced.

8.2.3 Technology

The PGMS is unnecessarily hindered by several technical issues:

- The current content management system is really designed for document management. Thus, it is not capable of supporting IM Principle #5: "When practical, the unit of analysis should be information, not documents." OCHA should replace its content management system with one that can support making parts of documents addressable by applications.

⁶⁴ The list of standards issues with OCHA's intranet is long, including problems with search, navigation, menu functionality, layout, and labeling.

- PGMS has been told that it cannot use guidance numbers (which are used by the World Bank and UNDP) to organize policies.⁶⁵ This is another argument for replacing OCHA's content management system.
- OCHA currently does not support a collaboration platform that allows for parallel development of documents by multiple participants that allows changes to be traced to their author, change rollback, etc.⁶⁶ This makes policy development slower and more error prone. This could be resolved through the use of collaboration software, for instance a wiki⁶⁷.

It is also unnecessarily hindered by software development issues:

- The current methodology does not do a sufficient job of capturing user requirements in enough detail so that users are assured they receive the application that they expect. Equally important, users are not given control of their requirements, rather, they are often dictated by the developers. For instance, the PGMS user team wanted to depict the organization of policies graphically. The development team told them they would have to settle for a much less user-friendly (and far less attractive) HTML table. Users should – with a few rare exceptions – control the specifications. Developers then provide estimates of project cost and duration.
- The development cannot be done as soon as PDSB would like because ITS does not have enough developers, even though PDSB has the money. ITS should develop a surge capacity through outsourcing.

8.3 Potential For IM Revolution

As the PGMS case illustrates, OCHA should avoid imposing a paper-based metaphor on Web technology. Merely posting policies as documents is what some technology gurus call “paving cow paths.”

Ideally, technology should allow policies to be collaboratively developed, with the full participation of the field⁶⁸, be published once, and then repurposed everywhere as needed (e.g., as full documents, as helps for forms, or built into the very logic of Web applications.) Divorced from the paper metaphor, there would only exist one version of a policy at one time, and policies could be updated centrally and made instantly available everywhere. The entire process could be

⁶⁵ The guidance numbers should be considered as another information domain, one that once mapped, would be managed by PGMS.

⁶⁶ Another candidate for this type of functionality would be the CAP.

⁶⁷ A wiki enables documents to be written collaboratively, in a simple markup language using a web browser. A wiki is essentially a database for creating, browsing and searching information. A defining characteristic of wiki technology is the ease with which pages can be created and updated. Edits can be made in real-time, and appear almost instantaneously online. Private wiki servers can require user authentication to edit, sometimes even to read pages.

⁶⁸ Which is an excellent way to create buy in to policies.

transformed from a publishing platform to a task-oriented aid (e.g., how do I open an office) closely linked to real work processes.

The people we interviewed at PDSB certainly do not want to “pave cow paths.” But OCHA’s business thinking is sometimes unnecessarily constrained by perceived limitations in technical and software development possibilities. The business should be encouraged to imagine innovative solutions and the IT group should be a partner in helping to realize the fruits of that imagination via technology. There are real issues with the infrastructure – specifically the content management system and intranet – that underpin the PGMS. These constraints are self-imposed by OCHA; they can and should be removed in months rather than years.

8.4 Specific Tasks For The IM Revolution

- Redesign the intranet to conform to commonly held Web standards
- Adopt a new content management system
- Adopt collaboration software and techniques and teach people to use them
- Improve the application development methodology, especially around requirements specification
- Map OCHA’s information domains
- Create oversight for each of OCHA’s information domains
- Create audience IM product portfolio management
- Alter PDSB’s charter to include scanning for opportunities to embed policies into forms, Web applications, and the fabric of OCHA’s work processes.

9 Appendix: Product Evaluation for ReliefWeb

ReliefWeb describes itself this way:

ReliefWeb is the world's leading on-line gateway to information (documents and maps) on humanitarian emergencies and disasters. An independent vehicle of information, designed specifically to assist the international humanitarian community in effective delivery of emergency assistance, it provides timely, reliable and relevant information as events unfold, while emphasizing the coverage of "forgotten emergencies" at the same time.⁶⁹

A major review of ReliefWeb done in 2006 confirms that ReliefWeb is a leader in providing information on humanitarian emergencies and disasters to the humanitarian community.⁷⁰ ReliefWeb's usage has grown steadily, from around 50 thousand average weekday hits in 2001 to over 200 thousand in 2005. It is reaching its target audience of decision makers and field workers.⁷¹ According to the report, "the loyalty of ReliefWeb users is strong, with 72% of all users surveyed reporting that they visit the site at least once a week."⁷² ReliefWeb's page hits track roughly to its main competitor, AlertNet (a Reuters service).⁷³

How secure is ReliefWeb's leadership position?

In the assessment of the IM Review Team, this leadership position is being put unnecessarily at risk for three principal reasons:

1. OCHA's IM practices make it difficult or impossible for ReliefWeb to report on key events in a timely way.
2. OCHA's IM practices make it difficult or impossible for ReliefWeb to do value-add analysis.
3. The technology being used to support ReliefWeb is not fit-to-purpose in terms of functionality and presentation.

The rest of this appendix will provide the analysis and detail behind these assertions.

⁶⁹ <http://www.reliefweb.int/rw/hlp.nsf/db900ByKey/AboutReliefWeb?OpenDocument>

⁷⁰ "Evaluation of ReliefWeb," Forum One Communications, Chris Wolz and Nam-ho Park, 2006. [http://www.reliefweb.int/rw/lib.nsf/db900SID/LTIO-6VLOJP/\\$FILE/5044_RW_evaluation_final_2006-v2.pdf?OpenElement](http://www.reliefweb.int/rw/lib.nsf/db900SID/LTIO-6VLOJP/$FILE/5044_RW_evaluation_final_2006-v2.pdf?OpenElement)

⁷¹ The subscriber survey shows that a large share of ReliefWeb users is indeed from its target audiences, with 42% coming from NGOs. 33% of survey respondents are staff members of International NGOs, with another 9% report being from "National and Local" NGOs. Respondents from ReliefWeb's other key audiences include 16% from UN agencies, and 11% from governments. In terms of professional roles, ReliefWeb is indeed reaching decision makers; 30% of users surveyed reported being Program Managers or Senior Managers. Another important audience for ReliefWeb is field-level workers, and 9% of users surveyed reported being "Relief workers / field level" (probably an underestimate as some field-based respondents may have selected functional roles other than "Relief Worker").

⁷² IBID, p. 25.

⁷³ IBID, p. 24.

9.1 Product Accord with IM Guidelines

In general, ReliefWeb is a consumer not a creator of information at OCHA. As such, it is higher on the information food chain and thus suffers more than the four other products reviewed in this report from violations to OCHA's IM guidelines

1. **Every IM product is part of a managed portfolio.** ReliefWeb is managed as a separate product from a separate section within the AIMB branch. There is little evidence that it is managed within the context of a portfolio of information products coming out of OCHA. For instance, what is its relationship to IRIN, situation reports, HICs, or field Web sites? Though it does seem to occupy a sustainable information niche, it appears that no one is managing these relationships in a concerted way.
2. **Each information category (domain) has a designated owner.** ReliefWeb maintains its own set of metadata for information categories like country. In fact, it has two separate databases for country information.

This is another example where consistent OCHA-wide domains need to be created, maintained, and properly governed. Otherwise, OCHA's different IM applications will never become effectively interoperable.

3. **Unconnected information islands should be avoided.** ReliefWeb is the victim of OCHA's information islands. Essentially, it needs to go to field offices, desks, IRIN, OCHAOnline, and elsewhere (pail in hand) to take the content from these information islands and add it to ReliefWeb.⁷⁴ Just gathering situation reports is a substantial effort made by well-trained and professional staff whose time would be better spent on improving content and its presentation.⁷⁵
4. **When practical, the unit of analysis should be information, not documents.** Once again, ReliefWeb is a victim of OCHA's general nonadherence to its IM guidelines, in this case its overreliance on documents. ReliefWeb has no reliable access to datasets of commonly accepted and normalized indicators and little access to mapping data to do its own analysis (or to allow users to do their own). (These are both prominent features of both the World Bank's "Doing Business" and FSAU's Web sites. See the Recommendations section for more information on both of these exemplars.) For these reasons, it often takes four weeks to put together a map around a humanitarian situation – individual documents need to be parsed manually in order to extract the need information.⁷⁶

⁷⁴ As the "Evaluation of ReliefWeb" report put it, "There is some sharing of content between ReliefWeb and other OCHA projects, but the evaluation team sees scope for more. ReliefWeb staff *manually* [emphasis the IM Review Team] collects and republishes a large amount of content every week from the IRIN News Web site, an OCHA project. Also, ReliefWeb's RSS feed is used by OCHA online to provide dynamic content on some country pages. Other than that, there is only limited cross-linking between the different OCHA sites including the HICs."

⁷⁵ All this time spent fetching information (80% of ReliefWeb staff time it has been estimated) is also a morale problem for ReliefWeb's staff who want to exercise their journalistic rather than administrative skills.

⁷⁶ Interview with ReliefWeb staff, July, 2007.

5. **Information – normalized and with clear provenance – is collected only once and re-used as necessary.** Much of the information that ReliefWeb presents is not normalized (e.g., the indicators embedded in situation reports are apples to oranges comparisons) and is collected multiple time in multiple areas (for instance, situation reports.)

Regarding provenance, ReliefWeb is fastidious about attributing its sources. But even here, there are problems. ReliefWeb currently does not allow for multiple sources for a single posting. In these cases, the ReliefWeb team must only attribute one of the sources for the posting, which reduces the resource's value and may anger the non-attributed contributors. This problem will be introduced in a future release, however the platform has made the implementation difficult from a programming standpoint.

6. **IM is seamlessly embedded into OCHA's practices.** There is very little embedding of information management into ReliefWeb. Some CAP and FTS information is made available to ReliefWeb automatically, but the majority of IMU and CAP staff do not have ReliefWeb accountabilities in their job terms of reference, therefore making their contributions largely discretionary or "at convenience," thus weakening ReliefWeb's comprehensiveness and timeliness. Other than this, OCHA staff is generally left to their own devices to find information. As the "ReliefWeb Evaluation" report stated, "OCHA staff does not generally see submitting content to ReliefWeb as a part of their job nor as something that will help them carry out their work."⁷⁷ One of the main sources of ReliefWeb information, situation reports, are only added to ReliefWeb manually, although a system had previously existed for GVA desks through "breaking news" function.

The process for creating and vetting situation reports, and for that matter all other types of information that will eventually appear in ReliefWeb, should be embedded into the work of those providing the information and, when possible, automated.

7. **Information can be easily manipulated and viewed in ways that make sense to OCHA's stakeholders.** While users can browse by country, date, source, emergency, sector, policy & issues, and other topics, these breakdowns are not always presented in a consistent way and are not as flexible as they could be. This stems both from the data model, the databases themselves, lack of policy, and "evolutionary" tendency of the classification system.

9.2 Opportunities and Challenges

If OCHA were to become the "intellectual leader" of the humanitarian world, then ReliefWeb would certainly be a logical channel for its knowledge products. Its staff – some with journalism backgrounds – would be well positioned to synthesize and add insight and analysis to the information coming from OCHA and its partners and donors.

Today, this is not possible. ReliefWeb's talented and dedicated staff spends too much of its time finding, formatting and classifying information. The technology that it uses to publish information allows collaborative working methods between the three teams in different time zones, however it impedes the gathering, vetting, and publishing process.

⁷⁷ "Evaluation of ReliefWeb," IBID.

9.2.1 Oversight

ReliefWeb, to be effective, cannot be governed as a stand-alone entity. It is at the end of the OCHA's information value chain and suffers from the chain's lack of consistency and structure. ReliefWeb must be seen, therefore, as part of a portfolio of products that need to be structured consciously to feed into it (wherever possible, without manual intervention). When practical, information should be unpacked from documents to speed the flow of information. And information should be normalized across OCHA's various information sources to greatly speed its analysis.

Without clear governance of information within OCHA at a portfolio level, ReliefWeb's potential will never be realized.

9.2.2 Standards

Future standards for ReliefWeb will need to address how information is stored throughout OCHA and how indicators are defined, collected, vetted, and shared. Today, information moves too slowly through OCHA because it is embedded in documents and because of a lack of consistent information definition.

9.2.3 Technology

ReliefWeb is currently built mainly upon IBM's Domino Notes platform, which is managed by ITS/ICTS.

The technology used to support ReliefWeb is not fit-to-purpose, and should be replaced wholesale as soon as is practical. The various technical problems with ReliefWeb substantially reduce its current effectiveness and is already unnecessarily exposing it to the risk of competitive disadvantage (e.g., to AlertNet). An incomplete list of the challenges of the current technical set-up includes:

- No way to preview content presentation before publication (and after entering content it often takes over two hours to view it)
- Multilingual support is difficult
- Dynamic mapping is hard to do
- ReliefWeb is too document-centric: there is no way to create headlines by importance, emphasis, anything that allows one to shape and editorial voice and idea. ReliefWeb is now held hostage to a rigid hierarchy that determines resource placement that cannot be overridden as needed without substantial effort.
- Development of new features such as crediting a document to multiple sources require excessive use of resources
- It is unnecessarily difficult to apply user analytics that could then be used to improve the product
- The underlying databases for metadata are complicated, error prone and do not allow easy updates, making maintenance and further development difficult
- The Domino platform is not evolving for publishing as fast as other, more industry-standard platforms, meaning that over time, ReliefWeb will become even more out-of-date.

A tool as important and costly as ReliefWeb should not be hampered through the use of sub-standard technology. Well-understood and industry-standard solutions exist. OCHA should use them for ReliefWeb.

9.3 Potential For IM Revolution

ReliefWeb has a potentially important role to play in helping OCHA achieve its vision of being the intellectual leader of the humanitarian community. It could be both the channel for OCHA's knowledge base and a contributor to it, since ReliefWeb staff can use their position as OCHA's information hub to synthesize and analyze the humanitarian information they receive from all of OCHA and OCHA's partners and donors.

What the Doing Business project is for the World Bank and the development community and what FSAU is to food workers in Somalia, ReliefWeb could be for OCHA and the humanitarian community.

9.4 Specific Tasks For The IM Revolution

- Rationalize the way information is collected, vetted, and communicated in OCHA so that information is collected once, has clear provenance, and is normalized. This is fundamentally a cross-product and cross-portfolio governance issue.
- Replace ReliefWeb's technology platform with modern Web content management and publishing technology.

10 Appendix: Product Evaluation for Situation Reports

OCHA situation reports are a key IM product for coordination and advocacy. They provide decision makers a baseline set of information from which to take action. They provide signals to the humanitarian community that resources are needed. And they provide OCHA's partners with a recognized forum from which to promote their activities.

With the Humanitarian Reform, OCHA's role as "knowledge broker" to the humanitarian community is starkly evident. To fulfill this role, OCHA needs to coax information from the clusters and then synthesize it in a meaningful way. Successful situation reporting does both. It gives partners a reason to provide information to OCHA because it validates and makes visible their work to the entire humanitarian community. It also, when done well, gives partners a holistic view of the situation that helps them make better decisions for their own work.

Often, situation reports are tailored to the situation (e.g., new small or medium size crisis, large crisis, long-term crisis, complex or natural disaster) and to their audience. Thus, successful situation reports have a strong client focus and, as in other areas, demonstrate OCHA's willingness "to do what it takes."

For all of their advantages, from an IM perspective situation reports have significant conceptual flaws. Most importantly, they conflate the gathering of information with reporting, making the information they contain hard to unpack and reuse.⁷⁸

In practice, situation reports have significant issues as well. They suffer from a clear lack of definition⁷⁹, the process by which they are triggered and distributed is ill-defined, and their content (and its quality) varies significantly.

10.1 Product Accord with IM Guidelines

As currently conceived, situation reports *do not* generally conform well to OCHA's IM guidelines. While there are certainly examples to the contrary, in general, there is a widespread belief in OCHA that situation reports don't effectively provide insight for decision making. Too often situation reports detail activities (how much food delivered, how many vaccinated) but not what these activities mean (is the situation improving or worsening, what other action should be undertake?). This lack of analysis provides value neither locally or to HQ.

The deficiencies in situation report analysis, we believe, have several sources. First, numerous interviewees in the field expressed to us that HQ is not clear on the type of content that it needs. This leadership gap causes inconsistency and lack of focus. Second, most offices are not set up to do the analysis that would provide insight for decision making. As emphasized in the section on "Capabilities," OCHA's offices do not commonly have the network of sources to obtain

⁷⁸ For instance, if one wants to understand the IDP situation in a particular country, one might be forced to read several situation reports, and there would be no guarantee that all of them reported on IDPs in the same place in the report, the definitions for IDPs might be different, and in fact, some reports might not mention IDPs at all. "Unpacking" this information is a laborious manual process – especially if one's aim is to do trend analysis over time. Coming up with meaningful aggregates across districts, countries, or regions is both expensive and time consuming, if it can be done at all.

⁷⁹ Sit reps really are several different types of reports (e.g., the local situation reports that are only shared within a country really serve a very different purpose than a situation report from the field that is then edited and published by a desk).

meaningful data in the field, nor the journalistic⁸⁰ and statistical skills to be able vet the data and analyze it for patterns and trends.⁸¹ A good situation report is not the product of an inspired solitary writer; it requires that an office have a well-functioning intelligence apparatus to support that writer's information and analysis needs.

1. **Every IM product is part of a managed portfolio.** Though efforts are underway by the leadership of CRD to better define situation reports as a consistent product within the overall portfolio of field reporting, this effort has not yet born fruit. It is not clear to people in the field what should trigger situation reports (some offices produce them on a regular basis, others do so rarely or not at all) and what they should contain. Some offices substitute situation reports for newsletters and flyers that are generally more targeted to local partners, donors, and governments. The role of situation reports in the overall portfolio of IM products from the field is not clear.
2. **Each information category (domain) has a designated owner.** Ultimately, CRD seems to be the owner of situation reports, though this is not completely clear. Sometimes countries send the reports to their desk in CRD for vetting, and sometimes they send out the information directly without any HQ intervention.
3. **Unconnected information islands should be avoided.** Situation reports themselves flow quite readily throughout the organization. As will be discussed shortly, the information within them is not structured in such a way as to allow for the easy use of that information.
4. **When practical, the unit of analysis should be information, not documents.** The situation report has as its unit of analysis the document, which creates several problems. The first, and most serious, is that key indicators (e.g., IDPs, food availability) are not clearly defined and, when and if they are provided, are buried within the report and are not readily available for aggregation across time or across geographies. Second, validation of the data cannot be done at the time of entry (e.g., to flag a missing indicator or to provide a list of possible values for the source of an indicator.) Third, having the situation report in a document format makes it difficult to provide form- and field-level helps (e.g., provided by the Policy and Guidance database.) We recommend that individual sections of situation reports be addressable so that they can be used as needed in what we have called the "Humanitarian Situation Analysis database⁸²," where the data can be repurposed in analytical tools such as spreadsheets.⁸³

⁸⁰ This includes policies for protecting field investigators, OCHA's "journalists." Many of these people are nationals, and it is not clear to them the degree to which OCHA and the United Nations will back them up in case of trouble with the local government.

⁸¹ Several HoOs and HCs expressed to us that having agencies and NGOs report their findings could be a conflict of interest. It was their experience that service providers sometimes overstated their effectiveness, leading to inappropriate resourcing decisions. These leaders believe that part of OCHA's role should be the confirmation of reports from partners.

⁸² Described in the section "How can IM better support humanitarian reform and specifically how can IM better support field operations and create a more coherent global approach?"

⁸³ The IASC Working Group has already endorsed OCHA to take the lead in facilitating a commonly agreed approach to needs assessment. It wrote: "the proposed commonly agreed needs assessment and analysis framework will serve as bedrock for establishing a global classification system for various situations in terms of varying severity. In particular, this system will address the following challenges: 1) development of standardized terms, indicators and assessment methodology; 2) creation of a common

5. **Information – normalized and with clear provenance – is collected only once and re-used as necessary.** Generally, the information in a situation report is only collected once. But the information’s provenance is often not clear (e.g., who reported the activities or indicators). There is currently very little effort to normalize the information (the definitions of an IDP may differ across individual situation reports and across districts, countries, and regions), making it impossible to aggregate information across situation reports without a significant reconciliation effort. And while the information in a situation report can be reused, doing so is difficult because it must be unpacked from its document form (this is especially true for indicator data).
6. **IM is seamlessly embedded into OCHA’s practices.** For OCHA to do its advocacy, funding, and coordination role, it must understand the situation on the ground and be able to report on it effectively to partners and donors. Situation reporting should naturally emerge from an OCHA office’s activities and not be seen – as it sometimes is today – as only a bureaucratic requirement. OCHA needs to make it clear to all in the organization that situation reporting is foundational to OCHA’s achieving its mission.
7. **Information can be easily manipulated and viewed in ways that make sense to OCHA’s stakeholders.** This is a key deficiency of the situation report. The only way to reorganize the information in ways that would be useful – by donor, partner, cluster, etc. – across situation reports is manually. The transaction costs of doing so are extremely high, rendering potentially valuable trend analysis prohibitively costly.

10.2 Opportunities and Challenges

Currently, situation reports conflate information storage and presentation, resulting in information that is hard to access and manipulate. Information should be stored in a way that it can easily be analyzed. Situation reports would be only one of many outputs from information created at the field level that is constantly being updated and improved. Collecting the information in a form rather than a document would allow key indicators to be systematically collected, vetted, and made available for analysis (to be done by OCHA or by its partners and donors).

10.2.1 Oversight

Clearly, defining the information used to describe situations in humanitarian crises should be the purview of CRD. This information could then be used by HQ, the field, donors, and partners in ways that make sense to them. Currently, there is not sufficient clarity about the triggers for situation reports or what they should contain.

CRD should take a leadership role in helping the organization define what information is required to understand a humanitarian situation as well as the frequency of reporting.

humanitarian mechanism for gathering baseline data; 3) coordination of sectoral assessments for the production of comprehensive sectoral and multi-sectoral assessments; 4) availability of resources for assessments at the onset of and throughout a crisis and for surveillance systems for the ongoing monitoring of the evolution of needs and of trends in real-time.”

10.2.2 Standards

As we have emphasized throughout this report, HQ should in most cases be the steward of standards, not their creator. Field offices have a great deal of experience with the challenges of finding and vetting information. They also know which information is most important for providing insight into decision making. CRD should work with innovators in the field to develop the minimum set of indicators and format for reporting on a situation, taking into account the differences in types of emergencies (e.g., natural vs complex.) This exercise will help OCHA take the best ideas from the field and innovate in the way it reports on situations internally and for its partners and donors. This process will also facilitate compliance in the field, since its leading practitioners will have been closely consulted and the “voice of the field” will have been heard.

The way in which the information is collected should be left to the field, as it will most likely vary greatly across the different field offices because of the resources available and the constraints of their situations. For example, though Ethiopia and oPt may both be excellent at gathering information, they may do so in very different ways. This diversity, while still adhering to the standards of what is to be collected when, will help to continue to foster innovation at the field level.

10.2.3 Capabilities

As mentioned earlier in the report, OCHA field offices overall need to boost their information gathering (journalistic) and data analysis (statistical) skills. The best field offices have worked very hard in isolation to achieve a high level of gathering and analysis skills. *OCHA can no longer afford to have individual offices reinvent the analytical wheel for every location and every crisis.* CRD should work with these offices to develop cases that can be taught across the field so that best practices are available to all.

10.2.4 Technology

Currently the technology for situation reports is essentially Microsoft Word and email. The IM Review Team recommends moving to a form-based way of collecting the information on a humanitarian situation that would have these characteristics:

- Could work on-line or off-line (for field offices with poor Internet connectivity.)
- Automated helps and tips would be available from PDSB’s Policy and Guidance database to provide guidance on how the form should be completed
- Fields would be validated at time of data entry (not later in the process)
- The form would automatically feed to OCHA’s knowledgebase..

10.3 Potential For IM Revolution

Having a consistent source of information from the field, continually updated, will transform OCHA. This is not too strong a statement. The Private Sector Development vice presidential unit of the World Bank’s “Doing Business” database⁸⁴ has made it *the* place to go to understand development issues from the lens of the private sector. The Food Security and Analysis Unit (FSAU) in Somalia⁸⁵ has become *the* place to go to understand food issues in the region. The

⁸⁴ <http://www.doingbusiness.org/>

⁸⁵ <http://www.fsasomali.org/index.html>

stature of these projects is unimpeachable, and they are widely used and quoted, because they have invested heavily in data collection, vetting, and analysis.⁸⁶ OCHA will be able over time to incrementally improve its indicators and analysis. The cost will not be small, but OCHA's humanitarian reform mandate as the cross-cluster coordinator requires this work.⁸⁷ The results will be that OCHA will achieve its vision of becoming the undisputed knowledge broker for the humanitarian community. The information will also provide the research base to allow OCHA to achieve its goal of becoming an intellectual leader in the humanitarian arena.

10.4 Specific Tasks For The IM Revolution

- Set the standards with the field for what information needs to be created and analyzed under what circumstances for humanitarian situations
- Develop a central repository of indicators (the OCHA knowledgebase).
- Develop case studies and other course materials to improve the field's capabilities to do information collection, vetting, and analysis to be used at inductions and trainings
- Have people from the field perform the trainings (perhaps hosted by the regional offices) to raise all OCHA's offices to best practice
- Develop a form to collect situational information that works in the field and automatically feeds into OCHA's knowledgebase.

⁸⁶ FSAU has over 100 people in Somalia from whom it gathers information; the World Bank has over 40 economists who work on the project.

⁸⁷ From our conversations with partners and donors, there is a great deal of appetite for OCHA to take on this role.

11 Appendix: How Effective Is OCHA's Governance of IM and How Does it Compare?

The IM Review Team has used a simple scoring system to evaluate the effectiveness of OCHA's governance of IM functions. This same scoring system has been used on several different organizations, which will allow us to compare OCHA with others.

The scoring system that evaluates these outcomes of governance effectiveness looks at these factors:

- the cost effective use of IM
- the use of IM to stimulate growth
- the use of IM to improve asset utilization (including human assets)
- the use of IM to improve business flexibility.

For each organization, the report rates each of these factors according to their importance to the success of the organization. For instance, for organizations facing a great deal of uncertainty, “business flexibility” might rate highly.

The report also rates the organization's effectiveness at optimizing these different factors. A score is then given for the overall effectiveness of IM governance performance.⁸⁸

Figure 6: Governance Effectiveness Calculator shows how these scores are calculated. The first four rows of figures give the importance of the outcome. The next four indicate how successful the organization has been at realizing the value of IM because of its IM governance.

For instance, for Comparator A, the “cost-effective use of IM” (rated 2) is not very important (presumably because not many resources are being dedicated to it). For this reason, even though Comparator A's rating for the successful “cost-effective use of IM” is also not high (also rated 2), its overall score would not suffer because this factor is not important. On the other hand, IM can evidently have a great deal of influence on Comparator A's ability to better use assets (rated 5). Nonetheless, it is only somewhat successful at using IM to improve its asset utilization (rated 3), and this *would* lower its overall score.

Note that the lowest possible score is 20 (when all of the factors are rated 1) and that the highest possible score is 100 (when all of the factors are rated 5.)

⁸⁸ This scoring system was adapted from one provided by Peter Weill and Jeanne Ross, *IT Governance: How Top Performers Manage IT Decision Rights For Superior Results*, Harvard Business School Press, 2004, pp. 239–40.

	Comparator A	Comparator B	Comparator C	Comparator D
Governance Outcome				
1=Not important, 5=Very important				
Cost-effective use of IM	2	1	5	2
Effective use of IM for growth	3	1	5	5
Effective use of IM for asset utilization	5	1	5	5
Effective use of IM for business flexibility	2	1	5	5
Success Measure				
1=Not successful, 5=Very successful				
Cost-effective use of IM	2	1	5	3
Effective use of IM for growth	3	1	5	3
Effective use of IM for asset utilization	3	1	5	3
Effective use of IM for business flexibility	3	1	5	3
Governance Performance	57	20	100	60

Lowest
Possible Score

Highest
Possible Score

$$\frac{(\sum_{n=1 \text{ to } 4} (\text{importance of outcome}\{Q1\} * \text{influence of governance}\{Q2\})) * 100}{\sum_{n=1 \text{ to } 4} (5 * (\text{importance of outcome}))}$$

Figure 6: Governance Effectiveness Calculator

So, what was OCHA's score?

In terms of the *importance of IM governance* the IM Review Team, with the help of OCHA staff members, gave its expert assessment and rated OCHA in the following way:

- The cost-effective use of IM was rated high because it is a big part of OCHA's budget (probably more than 20%).
- The effective use of IM for growth was rated low because OCHA does not intend to grow.
- The effective use of IM for asset utilization was rated highly because its assets (including its people) represent significant cost and when properly utilized provide significant benefit.
- The effective use of IM for business flexibility was rated as high as possible. OCHA is constantly facing new situations and must work with a constantly changing and diverse donor and partner population. Flexibility is essential to OCHA.

	OCHA
Importance of Governance Outcome	
1=Not important, 5=Very important	
Cost-effective use of IM	4
Effective use of IM for growth	1
Effective use of IM for asset utilization	4
Effective use of IM for business flexibility	5
Success of IM	
1=Not successful, 5=Very successful	
Cost-effective use of IM	2
Effective use of IM for growth	1
Effective use of IM for asset utilization	2
Effective use of IM for business flexibility	3
Governance Performance	46

Figure 7: OCHA's IM Governance Rating

In terms of the *success of IM at OCHA*, the same group rated OCHA in the following way:

- OCHA is seen as not using IM effectively, it currently receives enough funding to function, but is not efficient.
- Since OCHA is not currently growing, this factor was rated low (and since its importance was also rated low, this did not affect the score.)
- OCHA's use of IM was not seen as helping to leverage OCHA's assets, including its staff. For instance, because so many of OCHA's IM processes are siloed, often times double or triple entry of information occurs. Also, because information is difficult to find at OCHA (e.g., there is no federated search) its effectiveness is reduced.
- While people in the field try to react to situations rapidly (which is positive), and products like IRIN and ReliefWeb allow for quick reactions to new events, overall IM at OCHA organizationally is slow to react because of the lack of data standards, standard procedures, a common search, and a common infrastructure.

How does OCHA compare against other organizations? The following chart compares OCHA to ten other organizations already surveyed by the IM Review Team.

	OCHA	Bank	Energy	Govt 1	Govt 2	Govt 3	Govt 4	PS 1	PS 2	PS 3	PS 4
Governance Outcome											
1=Not important, 5=Very important											
Cost-effective use of IM	4	5	4	3	3	3	4	5	3	4	5
Effective use of IM for growth	1	3	5	2	1	2	1	3	4	3	2
Effective use of IM for asset utilization	4	4	5	5	5	5	5	5	5	4	5
Effective use of IM for business flexibility	5	5	4	4	5	5	5	4	4	4	5
Success Measure											
1=Not successful, 5=Very successful											
Cost-effective use of IM	2	4	2	2	3	2	3	4	4	4	4
Effective use of IM for growth	1	3	3	1	1	1	1	2	3	2	2
Effective use of IM for asset utilization	2	4	3	2	3	2	3	3	4	4	5
Effective use of IM for business flexibility	3	5	2	2	3	2	2	3	4	3	5
Governance Performance	46	82	51	37	57	37	51	62	75	67	87

Figure 8: OCHA Governance Performance vs Other Organizations

The comparator organizations include an investment bank, an energy company, several governmental organizations, and several professional services (PS) firms.

In our experience, organizations need to have a score above 60 to start to claim to have good IM governance. While OCHA's scores more highly than some of the organizations in this sample, it is still not at anywhere an optimal level for governance. The table on the next page may point to some of the reasons why.

The following table shows the characteristics of organizations with superior governance of IM and OCHA's performance against these characteristics. Overall, while some of the characteristics that would support good governance are evident, several key areas need improvement:

	Positive Characteristic For IM Governance	OCHA's Performance
↓	An IM-compliant culture where <i>top management</i> makes it clear doing a good job (and thus being eligible for advancement) means an employee must be constantly share and use information effectively.	Creating and sharing information is not a strong component in how management judges employees.
↓	Managers in leadership positions can describe IM governance.	It is not clear how groups like the IASC, IBWG, AIMB, and individual branches make decisions relating to IM.
↓	Senior management makes periodic announcements that reinforce and alert governance changes	This is not done effectively.
→	Formal committees add weight and cross-functional influence to governance	The IBWG does add visibility, and does have senior management involvement, but it does not seem to be a strong decision-making body. The IASC WG on IM has had limited impact as of this point in time.
→	There is an office dedicated to IM, which provides a recognized advocate, owner, and organizational home for IM governance	The AIMB branch is recognized as this home.
→	Members of the governance structure work with managers that do not follow the rules, using dialog to educate and address concerns	There is some effort to do this via FIS and ITS, but the governance structure is fuzzy and thus these efforts sometimes are not effective.
→	Portals or intranets with documents and procedures provide a single place for governance information	This is not yet fully implemented.
↓	Senior leaders are heavily involved in IM governance	Senior management is not currently involved.
↓	The organization has clear business objectives for IM investment	There is no apparent agreed to understanding within senior management around what these objectives should be.
↓	There are few renegades and more formally approved exceptions to IM standards.	There currently is not a formal exception process.
↓	The organization engages in fewer changes in governance from year to year	Governance structures are constantly changing at OCHA.

12 Appendix: Project Survival Test Results for ITS's Development Group

The IM Review Team gave the “Software Project Survival Test” – an evaluation tool created by a well-known writer on software development – to ITS members in both New York and Geneva. This tool measures the likelihood that a software development team can deliver quality software that meets specifications, and that is on time and on budget.⁸⁹

The New Yorkers self-scored much lower than the Geneva team. The IM Review Team – which has scored over 40 different projects over the last 10 years – scored ITS between the New York and Geneva scores. The questions, and the scores given by the IM Review Team, are presented here.

Criteria can be scored from 0 (do not agree at all) to 3 (fully agree.) The

Score	Criteria
1	Does the project have a clear, unambiguous vision statement or mission statement?
1.5	Do all team members believe the vision is realistic?
0	Does the project have a business case that details the business benefit and how the benefit will be measured?
1	Does the project have a user interface prototype that realistically and vividly demonstrates the functionality that the actual system will have?
1	Does the project have a detailed, written specification of what the software is supposed to do?
1.5	Did the project team interview people who will actually use the software (end users) early in the project and continue to involve them throughout the project?
1	Does the project have a detailed, written Software Development Plan?
2	Does the project's task list include creation of an installation program, conversion of data from previous versions of the system, integration with third-party software, meetings with the customer, and other "minor" tasks?
1	Were the schedule and budget estimates officially updated at the end of the most recently completed phase?
1	Does the project have detailed, written architecture and design documents?
0	Does the project have a detailed, written Quality Assurance Plan that requires design and code reviews in addition to system testing?
1	Does the project have a detailed Staged Delivery Plan for the software, which describes the stages in which the software will be implemented and delivered?
2	Does the project's plan include time for holidays, vacation days, sick days, and ongoing training, and are resources allocated at less than 100 percent?
2	Was the project plan, including the schedule, approved by the development team, the quality assurance team, and the technical writing team—in other words, the people responsible for doing the work?
Project Control	
1	Has a single key executive who has decision-making authority been made responsible for the project, and does the project have that person's active support?
2	Does the project manager's workload allow him or her to devote an adequate amount of time to the project?

⁸⁹ The tool was developed by Steve McConnell. <http://www.construx.com/Page.aspx?hid=1229#survival>

- 1 Does the project have well-defined, detailed milestones ("binary milestones") that are considered to be either 100 percent done or 100 percent not done?
- 1.5 Can a project stakeholder easily find out which of these binary milestones have been completed?
- 0 Does the project have a feedback channel by which project members can anonymously report problems to their own managers and upper managers?
- 0 Does the project have a written plan for controlling changes to the software's specification?
- 0 Does the project have a Change Control Board that has final authority to accept or reject proposed changes?
- 2 Are planning materials and status information for the project—including effort and schedule estimates, task assignments, and progress compared to the plan thus far—available to every team member?
- 1.5 Is all source code placed under automated revision control?
- 1.5 Does the project environment include the basic tools needed to complete the project, including defect tracking software, source code control, and project management software?

Risk Management

- 0 Does the project plan articulate a list of current risks to the project? Has the list been updated recently?
- 0 Does the project have a project risk officer who is responsible for identifying emerging risks to the project?
- 2 If the project uses subcontractors, does it have a plan for managing each subcontract organization and a single person in charge of each one? (Give the project full score if it does not use subcontractors.)

Personnel

- 1 Does the project team have all the technical expertise needed to complete the project?
- 1 Does the project team have expertise with the business environment in which the software will operate?
- 2 Does the project have a technical leader capable of leading the project successfully?
- 1 Are there enough people to do all the work required?
- 2 Does everyone work well together?
- 2 Is each person committed to the project?

Total

- 37.5 ___ Preliminary score. Add up the points next to each answer.
- 1.5 ___ Size multiplier. Write in 1.5 if the project team has 3 or fewer full-time– equivalent people including developers, quality assurance personnel, and first-level management. Write in 1.25 if it has 4 to 6 full-time–equivalent people. Otherwise, write in 1.0.
- 56.3 ___ Final score. Multiply the preliminary score by the size multiplier.

Score Comments

90+

Outstanding

A project with this score is virtually guaranteed to succeed in all respects, meeting its schedule, budget, quality, and other targets. In terms of Chapter 1's project needs hierarchy, such a project is fully "self-actualized."

80–89

Excellent

A project at this level is performing much better than average. Such a project has a high probability of delivering its software close to its schedule, budget, and quality targets.

60–79**Good**

A score in this range represents a better-than-average level of software development effectiveness. Such a project stands a fighting chance of meeting either its schedule or its budget target, but it probably will not meet both.

40–59**Fair**

This score is typical. A project with this score will likely experience high stress and shaky team dynamics, and the software will ultimately be delivered with less functionality than desired at greater cost and with a longer schedule.

< 40**At Risk**

A project with this score has significant weaknesses in the major areas of requirements, planning, project control, risk management, and personnel. The primary concern of a project in this category should be whether it will finish at all.

13 Glossary

Data	Generally understood as a point of change in a transaction usually captured in a system. Often, data is a change that without context has little meaning.
Information	A message, with a sender and receiver. It is usually bound by a repository. The value of information is determined by the recipient.
Information Leadership	The symbols and signals that organizational leaders use to indicate to the whole organization the value of information. It is evidenced by behaviors such as talking about the critical role of information in the functioning of the organization, advocating for and enabling the creation of information roles, structures and tools to support an information culture, rewarding and recognizing people who exemplify positive information behaviors.
Information Management	Is based on the organizational understanding that information is a critical asset to the vital functioning of the organization. As such, it needs to be managed. It focuses on the tools, practices, and policies that enable the effective and efficient use of information. It generally is concerned with information sourcing, creation, organization, storage, presentation, dissemination, and evaluation.
Information Management Governance	The way in which organizations strategically manage information as a tangible and an intangible asset. It is the responsibility of senior leaders and it is evidenced by IM Leaders prioritizing and allocating resources, including clarifying what is and isn't a strategic priority, advocating the organizational benefits of information, rewarding and recognizing information behaviors, and incentivizing organizational accountability for strategic information.
Knowledge	Experiential and based on a deep, rich, often tacit, understanding of a subject. Knowledge provides context, interpretation, judgment and insight to information. When aggregated in an organization knowledge is the capabilities and capacities to take effective action.
Knowledge Management	Helps an organization create, map, disseminate, and store knowledge more effectively for both internal and external constituents.
Knowledgebase	A special kind of database for knowledge management. It provides the means for the computerized collection, organization, and retrieval of knowledge.
Organizational Information Culture	Observable and durable organizational patterns of information behaviors. It is observable in patterns such as information sharing, information reciprocity, collaborative and active information creation, and the advocacy of positive social norms regarding information.

Point Solution	Solving one particular problem without regard to related issues. Point solutions are widely used to fix a problem or implement a new service quickly.
Portfolio Solution	A set of solutions that are considered as a whole in terms of efficiency and functionality from a user's point-of-view.